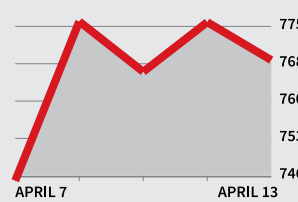


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76847.57 (-702.68)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23842.65	-207.95
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.12	-0.19
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.38	+0.66
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149410.00	-315
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	236981.00	-2953

POLLSCAPE.

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal targets the DMK, alleges corruption and weak governance in Tamil Nadu **p8**



PEAK GROWTH.

Company additions surged 36.7% to 2.47 lakh in FY26, recording the fastest growth in over a decade **p2**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

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QUICKLY.

EMERGENCY AID

Airlines may get 5-year, ₹5,000 crore credit line



New Delhi: India is set to cushion the impact of the West Asia crisis on its airline industry with about ₹5,000 crore under a proposed revamped Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme, sources told *businessline*. The credit window is likely to run for five years, with up to ₹1,000 crore per airline, extendable by ₹500 crore if the promoters match the infusion. The allocation forms part of a broader ₹2.5 lakh crore credit guarantee proposal that is under consideration. **p12**

thehindubusinessline.

wishes its readers a

Happy Tamil New Year



IMD forecasts ‘below normal’ monsoon as El Nino risk builds

BAD TIDINGS. Rain seen at 92% of LPA; may hit crops, stoke inflation and slow growth

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The South-West monsoon, which accounts for 75 per cent of the country’s annual rainfall of 116 cm, is likely to be “below normal” this year.

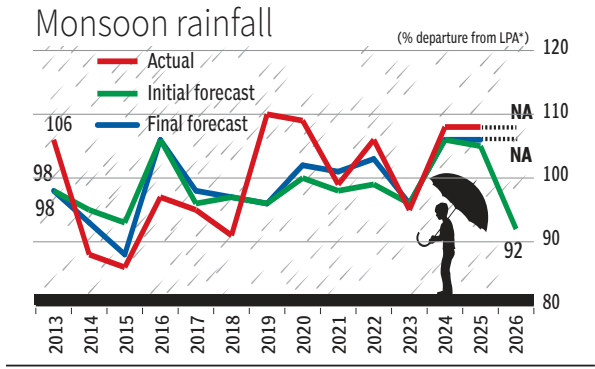
It will quantitatively be 92 per cent of the long period average (LPA) of 87 cm, said M Ravichandran, Secretary, Ministry of Earth Sciences.

The dominance of impact from a possible emergence of El Nino scales higher as the other two influencers — the Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) and the Eurasian snow cover — are either neutral or positive for the Indian monsoon.

The below-normal monsoon forecast, which could impact the country’s agriculture sector, comes at a time when input costs for growers are on the rise due to the Iran war.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) is projecting rainfall lower than the forecast of 94 per cent, made by private agency Sky-met last week.

If the IMD’s forecast turns out to be correct, this year’s



Source: IMD; LPA during 1971-2020 is 87 cm

monsoon rainfall will be the lowest since 2018, when India received 91 per cent of the normal rainfall.

INCREASED RESILIENCE However, as India’s irrigated area has been rising continuously (55 per cent of the net cultivable area has assured water sources), mainly driven by groundwater resources, the resilience to a lower rainfall has increased since the 2009 drought.

In 2018-19, due to the robust foodgrain production, lower rainfall did not affect retail food inflation, which declined to 0.1 per cent in FY

2018-19. In 2023, too, the country experienced El Nino.

However, it had a different impact as the rainfall of 94 per cent LPA affected the production of key crops such as pulses and oilseeds.

According to MK Dhanuka, Chairman, Dhanuka Agritech Ltd, the IMD forecast makes planning more critical.

“For key crops like paddy, cotton, pulses and oilseeds, the distribution and timing of rainfall will be critical. Rainfall variability could influence sowing decisions and regional demand for crop

protection products,” he said.

SUPER EL NINO

Briefing the media, IMD Director-General M Mohapatra said most climate models indicate that El Nino conditions are likely to emerge after June.

A Super El Nino has been predicted for this year by some global weather agencies.

Mohapatra said that out of 16 El Nino years since 1951, the monsoon was either below normal or deficient 9 times, whereas in 7 such years, there was normal or higher rainfall. The lowest monsoon rainfall was 78 per cent of the LPA in 1972 in an El Nino year.

KEY TO GROWTH

The South-West monsoon is key to the country’s economic growth as a good kharif harvest leads to a thriving rural economy.

This year, the below-normal forecast comes at a time when the agriculture sector is facing rising costs of fertilizers, crop inputs and fuel due to the US-Iran war.

Benchmarks recover, yet end in the red as peace talks fail

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Benchmarks ended Monday’s session in the red, though a sharp intra-day recovery from morning lows prevented a steeper fall.

The Sensex closed 702 points lower at 76,847, while the Nifty settled at 23,842, down 208 points.

The trigger was the collapse of the US-Iran talks and an order by US President Donald Trump to blockade the Strait of Hormuz, which pushed Brent crude above the \$100/barrel mark.

Gold prices declined by ₹1,162 to ₹1.51 lakh per 10 g in the futures trade.

RUPEE DOWN

The rupee fell about 65 paise against the US dollar on Monday amid the breakdown in talks, rising global crude prices and a stronger dollar. It closed at 93.3875 per dollar, down 66 paise from the previous close of 92.7275, after opening weaker at 93.30.

The benchmark 10-year bond was quoted at ₹96.845, with the yield rising about 3 basis points to 6.9395 per cent.

No immediate impact on India from curbs on Strait of Hormuz

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The latest directive by US President Donald Trump to block vessels to and from Iranian ports is unlikely to have an immediate impact on India’s crude oil and LNG supplies, though some disruption to LPG shipments from the Persian Gulf nation is expected.

PRICES MAY RISE

Over the past 45 days, India has reduced its dependence on crude oil imports routed through the Strait of Hormuz to about 30 per cent of total imports, down from over 50 per cent in January-February.

While the short-term impact remains limited — largely confined to LPG cargoes linked to Iran — the blockade is expected to exert upward pressure on global crude oil prices.

DIVERSIFIED SOURCING

Commenting on the situation, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Oil Ministry, said India had managed the transition “quite satisfactor-

ily” through diversification.

“We were sourcing significant energy — crude, LPG and LNG — from that region. Over the last 45 days, we have adjusted well. Crude sourcing has been diversified across more than 40 countries, and arrangements are in place,” she said.

“LNG supplies remain comfortable, and LPG cargoes have been secured, allowing us to maintain stable supplies for domestic consumers,” Sharma added.

LPG SUPPLIES UP

For commercial consumption, LPG supplies have gradually improved to about 70 per cent of normal levels.

However, some pressure persists, prompting the government to encourage consumers to shift to alternatives such as piped natural gas (PNG) and electric cooking solutions. Domestic LPG production currently stands around 45,000 tonnes per day, slightly lower than the earlier 46,000-47,000 tonnes.

Despite the shutdown of Nayara Energy operations, the government has been able to maintain output at this level, Sharma added.

Retail inflation hits 13-month high in March as LPG, vegetables turn pricey on war impact

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Driven by the rising prices of LPG and select vegetables, India’s retail inflation, measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI), climbed to a 13-month high of 3.4 per cent in March, up from 3.2 per cent in February, according to data released by the Statistics Ministry on Monday.

The uptick reflects the impact of the first full month of the West Asia conflict. While experts expect retail inflation to edge up in the near term amid volatile energy prices, they see it stabilising around the 4 per cent mark.

COSTLY FOOD

Data from the National Statistical Office (NSO) showed that food inflation had risen

Highs and lows

High Inflation			Low Inflation		
Item	Feb	Mar	Item	Feb	Mar
Silver Jewellery	160.88	148.61	Onion	(-)28.20	(-)27.76
Gold/Diamond/Platinum Jewellery	48.17	45.92	Potato	(-)18.47	(-)18.98
Coconut, Copra	46.16	45.52	Garlic	(-)31.10	(-)10.18
Tomato	45.18	35.99	Arhar, Tur	(-)16.00	(-)9.56
Cauliflower	43.76	34.11	Peas, Chickpeas	(-)8.26	(-)7.87

Source: NSO

to 3.87 per cent in March from 3.47 per cent in February. Prices increased sharply for gold and silver jewellery, coconut (copra), tomato and cauliflower. In contrast, several staples, including onion, potato, garlic, tur dal and chickpeas, recorded a deflation.

Within the ‘electricity, gas and other fuels’ category, inflation inched up to 1.65 per cent in March from 1.52 per

cent the previous month. Among States, Telangana recorded the highest inflation at 5.83 per cent, while Mizoram reported the lowest at 0.66 per cent.

“March inflation was modestly higher, signalling the first round of price pressures following the Middle East crisis,” said Radhika Rao, Senior Economist at DBS Bank.

Vikrant Chaturvedi, Asso-

ciate Director at Brickwork Ratings, said rising energy and fuel costs were beginning to exert upward pressure, though food inflation at 3.87 per cent remains broadly manageable.

STATUS QUO LIKELY

The monsoon outlook will be a key determinant of the inflation trajectory. Megha Arora, Director at India Ratings and Research (Ind-Ra), expects April inflation to rise to 3.8 per cent and cautioned that in the April-June quarter the print could exceed the RBI’s 4 per cent forecast.

Upasna Bhardwaj, Chief Economist at Kotak Mahindra Bank, said the RBI is likely to maintain status quo until there is greater clarity on the evolving balance between growth and inflation.

CRAFTING FAITH



RITUAL-READY. A child sits amid idols of ‘Baby Krishna’ (Unnikannan) displayed ahead of Vishu. Migrant workers in Vengalam, Kozhikode, craft and sell the idols for Vishu, the Malayalam New Year **K RAGESH**

TCS COO to investigate sexual harassment case at Nashik office; ACP-led SIT also set up

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran said the sexual harassment incident at the Nashik office of Tata Consultancy Services was being treated “with the utmost seriousness” and that Aarthi Subramanian, Chief Operating Officer at TCS, would lead the investigation into the incident.

“A thorough investigation is underway to establish the facts and identify all individuals responsible for this situation,” said Chandrasekaran, adding the complaints and allegations emerging from the Nashik branch were “gravely concerning and anguishing.”

“Appropriate and stringent action will be taken against those found guilty. Any necessary process improvements or corrective measures will be promptly

implemented and strictly enforced,” he added.

On Friday, the Nagpur police arrested seven persons Tausif Attar, Danish Sheikh, Shahrukh Qureshi, Raza Memon, Ashwini Chaunani, Shafi Sheikh and Aasif Ansari, with another employee, Nida Khan, absconding.

9 FIRs SINCE 2022

The police registered nine FIRs between July 2022 and March 2026, alleging sexual assault, harassment, hurt religious sentiments and coercion.

One survivor cited a false promise of marriage. Another complaint said employees had flagged concerns to Chaunani, but the accused were let off with verbal warnings.

Allegations range from inappropriate touching, stalking and obscene remarks to sexual exploitation and religious coercion.

A 12-member SIT, led by

an ACP-rank officer, has been formed, with the probe relying on both technical and physical evidence.

According to media reports, local politicians have sought strict action, terming it “corporate jihad.”

Former MP Priyanka Chaturvedi criticised Tata Consultancy Services for its “tone-deaf” response to the incident.

POSH AUDIT SOUGHT

The Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES) has asked the Union Labour Ministry to carry out a detailed audit of TCS’ POSH compliance, including constitution, independence and functioning of internal committees and the role of Human Resources personnel and senior management in handling such complaints.

It also asked for an examination of all sexual harassment complaints received,

pending or disposed of across TCS establishments.

Further, it called for a wider State-level audit of POSH compliance across IT and ITES companies operating in Maharashtra, especially large multinational organisations.

“This is not an isolated concern limited to one organisation. It raises serious apprehensions about the overall state of compliance and employee protection across the IT and ITES sector, particularly in Maharashtra which houses a large number of such establishments,” said Harpreet Singh Saluja, advocate, Bombay High Court and President, NITES.

STAFF SUSPENDED

On Sunday, TCS said it had suspended the employees pending enquiry and issued an internal communication urging staff to report similar incidents.

QUICKLY.

Sharon Pais takes over as head of Myntra



Bengaluru: Myntra has announced a leadership transition as Sharon Pais will be the head of Myntra and report to Kalyan Krishnamurthy, effective immediately. She succeeds former CEO Nandita Sinha, who is set to leave the Flipkart group after nearly 13 years across roles, including a stint as Myntra's CEO since 2022. **OUR BUREAU**

Volkswagen sees steep sales decline in China, US

Volkswagen AG's global car sales fell in the first quarter, dragged down by a slump in China, where competition from local brands has intensified. Deliveries declined 4 per cent to 2.05 million units, the automaker said Monday. Shipments dropped by 15 per cent in China and about a fifth in the US, with electric-vehicle sales particularly hard hit in both regions. **BLOOMBERG**

E-trucks drive stalls as costs, scrappage regulations bite

POOR SHOW. Parliamentary panel flags ‘nil achievement’ in heavy-duty EV targets

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

India's push to electrify freight transport is running far behind schedule, with fewer than 100 heavy electric trucks deployed under the ₹500 crore PM E-DRIVE scheme against a target of 5,643 vehicles.

A Parliamentary Standing Committee report tabled in early 2026 flagged “nil achievement” in physical targets for the heavy-duty segment as of January, even as the broader EV programme reached 58.6 per cent of its goals. The scheme, originally due to expire in March 2026, has since been extended to March 2028.

KEY HURDLES
The economics remain the first hurdle. A heavy-duty electric truck costs close to ₹1 crore, compared with ₹25-30 lakh for a diesel equivalent. While the subsidy is capped at ₹9.6 lakh, operators incur ₹3-4 lakh in scrappage logistics and compliance, leaving a net benefit of ₹5-6 lakh against a price gap



PRODUCTION BOOST. Tata Motors, Ashok Leyland and Blue Energy Motors are scaling electric truck capacity

of nearly ₹70 lakh. The scheme's design adds a structural constraint. Incentives are linked to scrapping older trucks of equal or higher gross vehicle weight — a condition that is difficult to meet in practice. Heavy-duty trucks in the 55-tonne category were introduced only around 2018 and remain in active use. “As a result, there are limited vehicles in this segment that are genuinely ready for scrapping,” said Amit Bhat, India Managing Director at the International Council on Clean Transportation (ICCT). The burden falls heaviest on driver-cum-operators, who make up nearly

70 per cent of the market and often lack the capacity to navigate the process. In March 2026, the Ministry of Heavy Industries allowed “aggregation”, enabling operators to combine smaller trucks to meet scrappage thresholds. In effect, this means scrapping two lighter trucks to qualify for one electric replacement, increasing documentation and compliance costs. Bhat suggests allowing any truck within the N2 or N3 categories to qualify, while industry discussions are increasingly questioning whether scrappage should remain a prerequisite for incentives. OEMs including Tata Mo-

tors, Ashok Leyland and Blue Energy Motors are scaling electric truck capacity, with deployments focused on closed-loop applications such as mining, cement and port logistics. Yet EV penetration in the commercial vehicle segment stood at just 1.83 per cent in FY26, despite overall CV growth of 12.5 per cent and 17.7 per cent expansion in heavy-duty trucks.

BOTTLENECKS REMAIN
Beyond policy and cost, structural bottlenecks remain. Charging infrastructure along freight corridors is limited, and the absence of a secondary market for electric trucks continues to deter smaller operators. CS Vigneshwar, President of FADA, said many end-of-life trucks continue to be dismantled in informal markets rather than at authorised scrapping centres mandated under PM E-DRIVE. Expanding scrappage infrastructure and improving state-level implementation will be critical to scaling adoption.

Company additions soar to a 10-year high in FY26

Yashaswani Chauhan
New Delhi

Company additions recorded a sharp acceleration in FY26, rising 36.7 per cent year-on-year to 2.47 lakh, according to the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. The jump marks the strongest annual growth in company additions in over a decade, indicating a strong formal business creation during the year.

DATA FOCUS.

“The increase in company additions in FY26 may reflect a combination of improving economic activity, continued digitalisation of incorporation processes, and growing preference for formal business structures,” said Karan Marwah, Partner and CFO Advisory Leader, Grant Thornton Bharat. “Easier access to technology, expanding entrepreneurial activity, and supportive business sentiment could also have contributed to higher registrations.”

Monthly trends of FY26 show that registrations peaked in December 2025, when 26,587 companies were added, the highest monthly figures. Additions remained elevated in the final quarter, with monthly registrations of over 22,000.

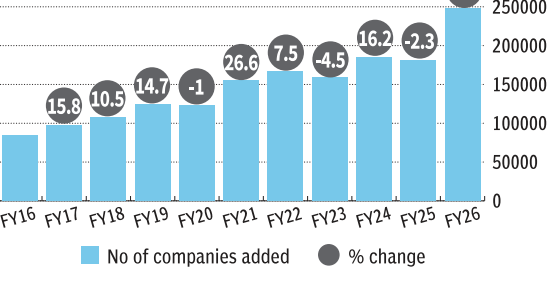
LOWER CLOSURES

While additions surged, company strike-offs remained contained. FY26 recorded 16,749 strike-offs, down 7.09 per cent from FY25, marking the third consecutive annual decline. Monthly numbers were relatively moderate throughout the year, largely staying below 1,500 except for the early months. Experts said the decline in strike-offs could be interpreted as a sign of greater business continuity, with more companies remaining on the register and continuing operations. It may also reflect a normalisation after earlier clean-up exercises, suggesting that multiple

Sign of strength

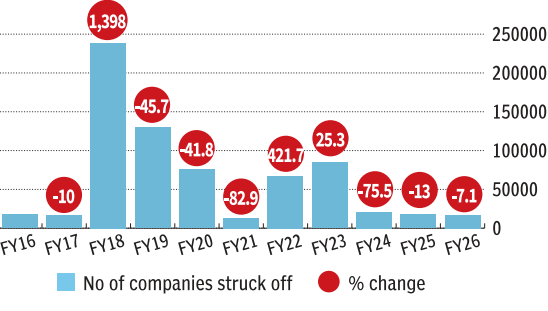
FY26 recorded 36.7% annual growth in companies added

Year-wise companies added (FY16-FY26)



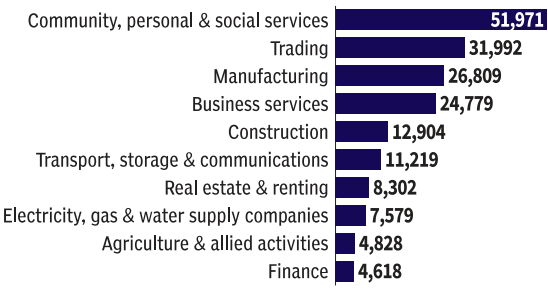
Strike-offs decline for third consecutive year in FY26

Year-wise companies struck off (FY16-FY26)



Service segments drive new company growth, followed by trading

Net addition of active companies between April 2025 to January 2026



Source: Ministry of Corporate Affairs

factors are influencing the trend.

LEADING THE GROWTH

Sector-wise data on net addition of active companies between April 2025 and January 2026 show services segments leading growth. Community, personal and social services recorded a net addition of 51,971 companies, followed by trading (31,992) and manufacturing (26,809). Business services and construction also posted steady gains.

At the State level, Maharashtra led with a net addition of 30,539 active companies, followed by Uttar Pradesh (21,706). Delhi, Telangana and Karnataka also featured among the top contributors. “Higher net additions in Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh may reflect the scale of their economies, population base, and breadth of business activity,” Marwah said, noting that diversified industrial ecosystems tend to support greater formal business formation.

NCLT accepts SBI’s petition against Venugopal Dhoot

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has accepted the SBI application invoking personal guarantee case against Videocon promoter Venugopal Nandlal Dhoot in the ₹6,158 crore loan default by the company to the bank in 2018.

The Videocon Telecommunications and Videocon Industries in 2010 and 2012 had availed various loans for working capital from SBI. Being the promoter of these companies, Dhoot had provided personal guarantee for these loans.

In 2018, the bank had sent demand notice to both the companies on default of



Videocon Group ex-Chairman Venugopal Dhoot

their loans and moved NCLT.

In 2019, NCLT allowed consolidation of the corporate insolvency resolution process of VIL. SBI had earlier initiated insolvency proceedings against Videocon group firms, with its ad-

mitted claims of over ₹4,671 crore.

In fact, the corporate insolvency resolution proceedings of the Videocon Group companies is presently pending.

Accepting the petition invoking personal guarantee, NCLT said the case will cease to have effect at the end of 180 days, or this Tribunal passes order before that.

LEGAL RIGHTS

During the moratorium period any pending legal action or proceeding in respect of any debt will be deemed to have been stayed, and lenders cannot initiate any legal action on defaulted debt.

The debtor cannot trans-

fer, alienate, encumber, or dispose of any of his assets or his legal rights, it added.

NCLT directed the resolution professional Ashish Narayan to collect the claims of lenders in 21 days and call for meeting of creditors in 28 days.

Sonam Chandwani, Managing Partner, KS Legal & Associates said though it is unlikely that a promoter of this scale would retain substantial assets in his individual name after prolonged financial stress, the current regime allows scrutiny of past transactions and reversal of suspect transfers, which may still yield recovery.

However, currently the admission standards are clearer, liability of the guar-

antor is treated as co-extensive and independent and insolvency professionals are actively examining transactions to identify preferential, undervalued or fraudulent transfers.

Ketan Mukhija, Partner and Co-Head, PE & VC, Kochhar & Co, said the inclusion of personal guarantors in the IBC framework created a parallel and creditor-driven insolvency mechanism directly against promoters, independent of the corporate debtor's CIRP.

This allows creditors to proceed simultaneously against both the company and its guarantors, thereby widening the recovery pool and increasing pressure on promoters, he said.

Sarovar Hotels expands in small cities, pilgrim hubs

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Sarovar Hotels sees continued traction in tier II and tier III cities as well as pilgrimage centres, its Chief Executive Officer Jatin Khanna said on Monday.

“Markets such as Ujjain, Omkareshwar, Rishikesh and other spiritual hubs along with industrial and infrastructure-led growth centres will be key focus areas for us,” Khanna said.

Since January 2025, Sarovar Hotels added 73 new hotels strengthening its domestic footprint. “Our development pipeline remains robust with 20-plus openings planned in 2026. These include a mix of business, leisure and pilgrimage

destinations such as Kota, Mathura, Bhubaneswar and Dharamshala,” Khanna said.

Sarovar Hotels has a strong focus on midscale segment which is also the largest category in India in terms of existing room inventory and pipeline. The company is also adding hotels to the upscale segment under the Royal Tulip brand in Nepal.

These growth plans come amid strong surge in domestic travel. Average room rates have surpassed pre-pandemic levels as demand continues to outpace supply.

In CY 25, it clocked revenue of ₹2,000 crore. This year, the chain is targeting 15 per cent growth over 2025. Currently, it has a portfolio of 150 hotels with 11,000 keys across 87 destinations.

Wage protest turns violent in Noida, Faridabad

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Protests over wage hikes by factory workers in Noida (Uttar Pradesh) and Faridabad industrial area (Haryana) erupted early on Monday and escalated within a few hours with stone pelting and incidents of arson that created chaos and massive traffic jams in the National Capital Region (NCR).

A large number of workers from various industrial units in Phase-2 and Sector 60 of Noida gathered in the morning to press for their long-pending demand for a salary revision.

Officials said the workers were demanding a wage hike on the lines of neighbouring Haryana, among other things. Similar protests were also reported from Sector 62



LABOUR UNREST. Security personnel stand guard as factory workers stage a protest demanding a hike in wages in Noida, Gautam Buddh Nagar district, Uttar Pradesh

and Sector 84, including at a Motherson company unit. Protesters blocked the National Highway 9 which is close to the Ghaziabad border and a key route connecting Delhi and western UP.

A spokesperson at Samvardhana Motherson International clarified that the protest was a broader labour issue affecting multiple in-

dustries in Noida and some other cities, driven by misinformation being spread about wage revisions.

“Our operations remain compliant with all applicable laws with no material impact on the company. The authorities are working closely with the industry to bring things back to normal as quickly as possible,” the spokesperson

Funskool revenue up at \$40 m in FY26, despite tariff issues

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Toy-maker Funskool India Ltd, promoted by MRF Group, has recorded a turnover of \$40 million in FY26, which is marginally short of their initial growth targets due to the US tariff tensions. The company said it has recorded an average growth of 14 per cent over the past two years, with exports growing at 19 per cent year-on-year during the

same period. Given the ongoing geopolitical situation in West Asia, the company is anticipating a moderate growth outlook of 12-15 per cent, with plans to revisit targets after Q1FY27, once the situation stabilises.

NOTICEABLE IMPACT

The US tariffs had a noticeable impact on export momentum in the second half of FY26, KA Shabir, CEO, Funskool India, told *businessline*. “But, we were still able to maintain overall growth rate by ways such as offering price adjustments to customers to offset the tariff differential and engaging closely with them to prevent relocation of projects to countries like Vietnam and Indonesia,” he added.

“We also undertook direct engagement with some of our customers, including visits to their offices in Hong



KA Shabir, CEO, Funskool India

Kong, which helped retain business and has resulted in a positive order outlook for Q1 of FY27,” Shabir said.

Funskool, over the past year, has also strengthened partnerships with global companies such as Spin Master (Canada), Moose Toys (Australia), Melissa & Doug (US), and Asmodee (France), along with several other European partners. Last year, it has also established new partnerships with Learning Resources (US)

and Buffalo Games (US).

However, just as the tariff situation was stabilising for the industry, the US-Iran war and the resulting tensions in West Asia have brought challenges in the form of input cost volatility.

KEY CONCERN

“While the order book remains encouraging, the sharp increase in raw material prices, especially plastics, is a key concern. Currently, existing and pipeline inventories are supporting production until end-April/early May, but beyond that, higher input costs will start impacting exports,” Shabir said.

“Overall, while demand remains good, cost pressures and margin management are the challenges for exports in the current environment,” he added.

On the bright side, the CEO said FTAs have opened

up opportunities for exports by improving market access and making Indian products more price-competitive.

EU customers are waiting to see how the actual duty advantages play out, he added.

As for the expansion of its Goa plant, Shabir noted that the facility is expected to be completed by March 2027.

The domestic business, which holds a lower share relative to exports, has grown at a modest single-digit pace over the last two years, Funskool said. In the domestic business, Funskool expects a significant shift in growth momentum for FY27, driven by the introduction of new categories such as friction vehicles under the brand ‘BlazeTrix’ and remote-control cars under ‘VoltRush’, along with the addition of popular licences such as Paw Patrol.

Sify data centre IPO depends on market conditions, says CFO Vijay Kumar

Rohan Das
Chennai

Sify Infinit Spaces, the data centre subsidiary of Sify Technologies, is on track for its initial public offering (IPO) with the company discussing the timeline of the listing with its bankers.

Speaking to *businessline* post the company's March quarter earnings, MP Vijay Kumar, Group CFO said that the company has received all necessary approvals from SEBI and are now evaluating a possible time of listing.

“The banker's view is that the volatility in the market is too high. It has to stabilise for at least some reasonable period before we can hit the market. We do not have any pressure for capital raise im-

mediately because for the projects for this year we have done the financial closure earlier,” he added.

Sify Infinit Spaces Ltd had filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus with Securities and Exchange Board of India earlier this year.

The company sold 17 MW of data centre capacity in the financial year ending March 2026. Cumulatively, sold capacity stood at 129 MW and the business has contracted an additional 81 MW to be delivered in FY26-27.

POSITIVE IMPACT

As for the impact of the war in West Asia, Kumar said that the crisis has had a positive impact on the company's data centre business.

Sify Technologies on Monday reported a net loss

of ₹37 crore for the fourth quarter ended March 2026, as against a net loss of ₹58 crore for the corresponding quarter last year. Revenue during the quarter was up 24 per cent to ₹1,202 crore.

For the full financial year ending March 2026, the net loss stood at ₹136 crore as against ₹78.5 crore loss in the previous year. Revenue for the year went up 12.5 per cent to ₹44,877 crore.

According to Kumar, the loss for the year included a one-time expense of ₹40 crore for converting Compulsorily Convertible Debenture held by Kotak as equity. Moreover, he said that the company is investing heavily in upskilling and building capabilities and as a result he expects some pressure for a few more quarters.

businessline.
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QUICKLY.

BEML secures \$37 m order from West Asia region

Bengaluru: BEML Ltd has secured an export order valued at \$36.38 million from the West Asia region. Traditionally deployed in large-scale mining operations, these heavy earthmoving equipment have now been re-engineered for infrastructure development applications. The heavy equipment platforms are designed for high-intensity reconstruction and strategic infrastructure development, incorporating critical performance and survivability enhancements to meet stringent global standards. **our BUREAU**

HPCL issues tender seeking tanker to load Russian LPG

New Delhi: Hindustan Petroleum Corp has issued a rare tender seeking a liquefied petroleum gas tanker to immediately load propane and butane from Russia's Ust-Luga port, a tender document seen by Reuters on Monday showed. The vessel, to be loaded with 12,000 tonnes of and 8,000 tonnes of propane for discharge on India's west coast, must not be under sanctions and must have no links to Iran, the document said. **REUTERS**

US' Hormuz blockade spells double trouble for Indian exporters

GROWING CONCERN. The sudden escalation may lead to fresh uncertainty and rise in input costs

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The US naval blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, announced by President Donald Trump on Sunday following the failure of peace talks with Iran, may lead to double trouble for Indian exporters if it creates a new layer of restrictions leading to further disruptions.

While the industry is already feeling the squeeze of rising costs of raw materials, spiralling freight rates and a looming energy crisis due to Iran's blockade of the strait, much of the added anxiety stems from the lack of clarity regarding the scope of the US move, say experts.

BULLISH OUTLOOK
Despite these complexities, the Indian government maintains a long-term bullish outlook.

Responding to a question from *businessline* on whether India's exports will grow in FY27 given the on-going war and regional volatility, Com-



WAR CRISIS. The blockade also affects India's shipments to its top destinations, the US and the EU

merce Minister Piyush Goyal remained confident.

"We will grow because now we have many more free trade Agreements (FTAs) that are coming into play," Goyal said, suggesting that new trade frameworks, with partners like the US, the EU, the EFTA bloc and Oman, will provide the resilience needed to navigate the current geopolitical storm.

Meanwhile, exporters are concerned that this sudden escalation would effectively neutralise earlier hopes of a diplomatic breakthrough that might have provided Indian trade routes with much-needed leeway. "We need to

see exactly how the US blockade works. Any extra blockade would be very bad for Indian exporters as we were finally hoping that we had some leeway (with Iran), and that would now disappear," said Sanjay Jain, CMD, TT India Ltd.

Jain said there was a "360 degree" impact of the escalating crisis on the entire textiles and clothing industry, with supply chains getting choked and not just prices, but availability also becoming a challenge.

Over \$60 billion of exports from India, including key commodities like tea, agro-products and engineer-

ing goods, annually destined for Gulf economies rely on Hormuz-linked shipping lanes.

Additionally, the blockade also affects India's shipments to its top destinations, the US and the EU, as it forces re-routing leading to higher shipping (in some cases a 400 per cent rise) and insurance costs and much longer transit time through the Cape of Good Hope.

Shortage of energy and petroleum-based inputs is also crippling production in various export units spread across the country.

India's exports in April-February 2025-26 posted a small growth of 1.84 per cent to \$402.93 billion (year-on-year), while exports in February 2026 marginally declined.

ADVERSE IMPACT

Trump's proposed blockade of the Strait of Hormuz may have a further adverse impact on both prices and availability of petrochemical-based components used by the leather and footwear sec-

tor, one of the worst affected by the West Asia crisis, said Israr Ahmed, a Chennai-based top exporter of leather products.

"Demand of final product is also at risk as inflation rises. We may see demand dropping in the next few months," Ahmed said.

There is a fear now that all movements from all countries in the Gulf of Hormuz will stop and energy shortage will hit engineering goods manufacturers even more, said Pankaj Chadha, Chairman, Engineering Exports Promotion Council of India. "All derivatives of oil including furnace oil, cutting oils, and rust prevention oils (important for manufacturing) are up 50 per cent already," Chadha said, adding that it may get worse.

While exporters fear the worst, much depends on what Trump would do next, said Biswajit Dhar, former Professor, Jawaharlal Nehru University.

(With inputs from TE Raja Simhan, Chennai)

FTAs to aid India's export growth despite global turmoil, says Goyal

Our Bureau
Chennai

Despite the US tariffs, the West Asia crisis and a series of geopolitical tensions, India has maintained pace of merchandise exports and grown its services exports, Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal told *Hindu* group of journalists on Monday.

Responding to a question on India's export prospects for FY27, he said that they anticipate growth in exports with many more free trade agreements (FTAs) coming into play.

ON US TRADE DEAL

On India's much-awaited trade deal with the US, the minister said that they have finalised it, but a trade deal should give India preferential market access compared to our competitors. "In fact, UK and EU in their history would not have cleared any FTA as fast as they will do with India," he said.

"We finalised the trade deal and then the US Supreme Court order took away that competitive edge. We have to work with the US to see how that competitive edge can come back to us. And the trade deal is on. The US FTA



Piyush Goyal

will happen as soon as we can get that competitive edge," he said. "On June 1, Oman FTA will be effective...We are trying to operationalise the UK FTA to come into effect on May 1," the Union Minister said, about India's other trade deals. The India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) has already come into effect and the trade deal with New Zealand are among the others in the offing, he added.

On the impact for India from the West Asia crisis, Goyal said despite the stress on energy prices, India maintains energy costs for the common man. "There are no lines at any petrol pump. LPG cylinders are available for all. In LNG also India is restoring very fast and its almost up to 80-90 per cent," he said. Though fertilizer prices are up, the Centre has absorbed that entire increase, he added.

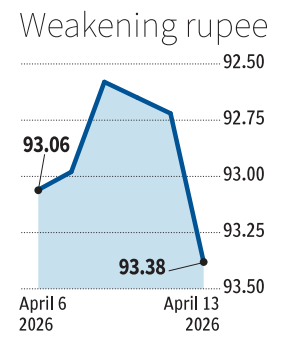
Surge in crude oil prices drags rupee down by 66 paise

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The rupee slumped about 66 paise against the US dollar on Monday in the wake of failure of the US and Iran to reach a truce deal, rising global crude oil prices, and a strengthening dollar.

This came even as RBI Deputy Governor T Rabi Sankar, in his weekend comments at the Foreign Exchange Dealers' Association of India annual conference in Paris, reportedly criticised players in the forex market for their role in aggravating the Rupee's weakness.

The rupee closed at 93.38 per dollar, down about 66 paise, against previous close of 92.72. It opened weaker at



93.30 per dollar against the previous close.

Sankar underscored that the rupee came under pressure not only due to FPI-related outflows but also the arbitrage between onshore and offshore markets.

In order to ensure orderly conditions in the foreign ex-

change market, the Reserve Bank introduced a prudential measure on March 27 that limited the net open position in INR (NOP-INR) of authorised dealers in the on-shore deliverable market to within \$100 million at the end of each business day. This was aimed at curbing excessive speculative positioning and mitigating systemic risks.

UNWINDING POSITIONS
Amit Pabari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, observed that a silent force — banks unwinding their dollar positions to comply with the RBI's Net Open Position (NOP) cap (deadline ended on April 10, 2026) — was at play that held up the rupee. This created a steady supply of dollars a

cushion that quietly supported the rupee.

"But now? The deadline is over. The cushion is gone. Just as one support faded, another risk emerged and this one comes from far beyond domestic borders. The US President Donald Trump has escalated tensions by announcing a potential blockade of the Strait of Hormuz after failed negotiations with Iran. This narrow stretch isn't just any waterway; it carries nearly 20 per cent of the world's oil supply," he said.

Pabari assessed that a \$10 rise in crude can widen the trade deficit by \$13-15 billion annually. This pressure flows into the current account, stretches fiscal balances through subsidies or

tax cuts, and ultimately weighs on the rupee.

Dilip Parmar, Senior Research Analyst, HDFC Securities, said the rupee extended its losing streak to three sessions, recording its deepest drop in a fortnight.

"The downward pressure stems from a spike in crude oil prices after President Trump ordered a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz. All eyes are on the 10:00 AM EST window for potential US military movement following failed diplomatic talks.

"Meanwhile, local sentiment is cautious as investors await India's CPI data before Tuesday's holiday. Technically, the dollar-rupee pair is trading between a support level of 92.70 and resistance at 93.65," he said.

World Bank chief sounds alarm about looming jobs crisis

Reuters
Washington

The West Asia war will dominate global finance officials' talks this week in Washington, but World Bank President Ajay Banga is sounding the alarm about a bigger, looming crisis: a huge gap in jobs for the 1.2 billion people who will reach working age in developing countries in the next 10-15 years.

At current trajectories, those economies will generate only about 400 million jobs, leaving a deficit of 800 million jobs, Banga told Reuters.

The former Mastercard CEO admits that focusing people on the long-term is daunting, given a series of short-term shocks that have buffeted the global economy since the Covid-19 pandemic, the most recent being the war in West Asia.

He says he's determined to ensure that finance officials stay focused on those longer-term challenges like creating



Ajay Banga, World Bank President

jobs, connecting people to the electricity grid and ensuring access to clean water.

LONGER VELOCITY

"We have to walk and chew gum at the same time. Short-velocity cycle is what we're going through. Longer velocity is this jobs circumstance or water," Banga said in an interview.

Thousands of finance officials from around the globe will gather in Washington

this week for the spring meetings of the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund under the shadow of the US-Israel war with Iran that threatens to slow global growth and jack up inflation.

JOB CREATION

The World Bank's governing body, the Development Committee, outlined plans to work with developing countries to streamline policy and regulatory conditions that have hampered investment and job creation for years.

Discussions will touch on transparency around permits, anti-corruption, labour law, land law, impediments to opening a business, logistics, better trade systems, and non-price barriers in trade, Banga said.

He is upbeat that solutions can be found to help find employment — and dignity — for young people and create opportunities for private companies catering to their needs.

Govt mulls 21% ethanol blending in wake of W. Asia war

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government on Monday hinted that India can increase ethanol blending in petrol to 21 per cent from the current 20 per cent.

Citing the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS), Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI) Additional Secretary Hanif Qureshi said that E21 can "be there."

Speaking at the inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia on Monday, he said, "The government is committed to using biofuels as far as possible and E20 has already taken place. The BIS has said that +/- 1 per cent blending can be there." The ethanol

blended petrol (EBP) programme has helped India save roughly 6 million tonne (mt), or around 44 million barrels annually. In the last 10 years, the programme has helped over 18 mt of crude oil imports, saving ₹1.36 lakh crore in foreign exchange.

Qureshi also pointed out that flex fuel vehicles are another avenue to reduce import dependence on crude oil.

FLEX FUEL MODELS

"There is also a programme of flex fuels and the industry has already come up with models, which are compliant with flex fuels. So, flex fuels means that from E20 to E85. The engines can take that blend without any degrada-



Hanif Qureshi, Additional Secretary, Ministry of Heavy Industries

tion in performance. So, we have seen development of 4-wheelers as well as 2-wheelers, which are capable of using flex fuels. So, we are confident that the use of flex fuels will also grow. That will also ease pressure on crude

oil imports," he emphasised. In the ethanol supply year (ESY) 2025-26, which began in November 2025 and will last till October 2026, the total supply requirement for 20 per cent blending is 1,350 crore litres.

The volume of ethanol required for 21 per cent blending can easily be met from domestic sources considering India now has overcapacity of grain-based capacity.

For instance, in ESY 2025-26, the PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) floated tenders to procure around 1,050 crore litres of ethanol, against which eligible offers aggregated to 1,759 crore litres, indicating substantial surplus.

Per the roadmap for eth-

anol blending in India 2020-25 prepared by the Inter-Ministerial Committee led by NITI Aayog, ethanol requirement for 20 per cent blending in ESY 2025-26 was estimated at 1,016 crore litres, of which 466 crore litres was projected from non-sugar based sources.

Public sector OMCs achieved the target of 10 per cent ethanol blending in petrol in June 2022, five months ahead of the target during ESY 2021-22.

Ethanol blending levels thereafter increased to 12.06 per cent in ESY 2022-23, 14.60 per cent (ESY 2023-24), and 19.24 per cent (ESY 2024-25). 19.98 per cent till March 15, 2026 (ESY 2025-26).

Net sales of non-financial private companies rise 11.4% in FY25: RBI data

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Net sales of non-financial private companies increased at a slower pace of 11.4 per cent in 2024-25 as compared to 11.7 per cent in the previous year, according to Reserve Bank data released on Monday.

The RBI released data relating to financial performance of non-government non-financial (NGNF) private limited companies during 2024-25 based on audited annual accounts of select 15,919 companies reported in the Indian Accounting Standards (Ind-AS) format.

Services sector recorded 13.5 per cent growth in net sales during 2024-25, driven by "Trade — wholesale & re-



ON THE RISE. Services sector recorded 13.5 per cent growth in net sales during 2024-25

tail, 'Real Estate' and 'Transport and Storage services' sub-sectors.

Sales growth in the manufacturing sector moderated marginally to 9.2 per cent in

2024-25 from 9.4 per cent in the previous year.

Total paid-up capital (PUC) of these companies amounted to ₹8,44,198 crore as at end-March 2025, which

covered 40.3 per cent of the total PUC of NGNF private limited companies.

At the aggregate level, operating expenses increased relatively at a higher rate in 2024-25 as compared to the previous year, driven by manufacturing expenses and remuneration to employees, the RBI said.

"Remuneration to employees increased for services sector while it moderated for the manufacturing sector," it said.

Further, operating profit and profit after tax continued to show double-digit growth in 2024-25 on top of high growth in 2023-24.

Gross capital formation (which includes fixed assets and inventories) accounted for 48.2 per cent of total fund usage, up from 45.3 per cent in the previous year.

शिरूर नगरराजप्पद, जि. पुणे, शिरूर
दूरध्वनी क्र. 02138-222122
Email: shirur.pune@gmail.com
Parent Portal : <http://mahatenders.gov.in>

ई-निविदा सूचना
ई-निविदा सूचना क्र. 04 सन - 2026-2027
ई-निविदा सूचना क्र. 2026.DMA.1294721.1 अन्वये प्रसिद्ध करणेत आलेली ई-निविदा सादर करणस दि. 13/04/2026 ते दि. 07/05/2026 पर्यंत रु. 3.00 वाजेपर्यंत येणार असून याची सर्व संबंधितांनी नोंद घ्यावी. या निविदेच्या पुर्वअर्हता अटी व सविस्तर निविदा सूचना शासनाच्या <http://mahatenders.gov.in> या संकेत स्थळावर उपलब्ध आहे.

XXX
(श्री. पंकज काकड)
रचना सहायक

XXX
(श्री. प्रितम पाटील)
मुख्याधिकारी
शिरूर नगरपरिषद, घोडनदी

Roots Multi Clean Limited ("Company")
(CIN: U36999RT1992PLC003662)
Regd. Office: R K G Industrial Estate, Ganapathy, Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu - 641 006

NOTICE
Pursuant to the Order of the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Chennai Bench, dated 2nd April 2026 approving the Selective Share Capital Reduction Programme under Section 66 of the Companies Act, 2013, Friday the 17th April 2026 is fixed as the Record Date for taking on record of the list of Identified Shareholders in terms of resolution passed by the shareholders at their Extra-ordinary General Meeting dated 27th March, 2025 and whose names appear in the Register of Members of the Company or in the records of the Depositories as beneficial owners of the shares, for the purpose remittance of the consideration towards the implementation of the Selective Share Capital Reduction Programme.

For Roots Multi Clean Limited
Sd/- **R K Umadhevi**
Director (DIN: 01067950)

Place : Coimbatore
Date : 13-04-2026

KERALA CASHEW BOARD LIMITED (KCB)
T.C. - 29/4016, Women's College-Bakery Junction Road, Vazhuthacaud, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, India - 695014.
Tel.: +91 471 2252855, 2320089 email: kcb@keralacashewboard.com

No: KCB/72/100/2026/IVC(18) **Date: 10.04.2026**

RE-TENDER NOTICE
Kerala Cashew Board Limited invites e-tenders through e-procurement portal for the import of 2000-5000 Metric Tonnes of quality **Dried Raw Cashew Nut of 2026 crop of Cote D'Ivoire origin**, with the following quality specifications as import basis.
(Tender ID- 2026_KCBL_837098_2)

Outturn : 48 lbs. per 80 Kg bag **Nut Count : 190 Numbers per Kg**

Last date for submission and uploading e-tenders	1700 hours on 23rd April 2026
Opening of e-tender	1100 hours on 24th April 2026

All details can be viewed, downloaded and applied through the e-procurement portal www.etenders.kerala.gov.in
CHAIRMAN & MANAGING DIRECTOR

MAITHON POWER LIMITED
(Contracts Department)
Maithon Power Ltd, Village: Dambhui, PO Barbindia, PIN-828205, District-Dhanbad

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
The Maithon Power Limited, a joint venture between Tata Power and DVC invites expression of interest from eligible vendors for the following packages:

S. No.	Ref. No	Package Description
1	2000092852	AMC for the Heating, Ventilation & Air Conditioning system for 3 Years at MPL

Contact Details: Ms. Debarati Bhattacharyya - Procurement, Mobile-9234000596, Email id: debarati.b@tatapower.com & Mr. Rabish Kumar, Email id: krabish@tatapower.com. For details of prequalification requirements, bid security, purchasing of tender document etc., please visit our website ([URL: https://www.tatapower.com/tender/tenderlist.aspx](https://www.tatapower.com/tender/tenderlist.aspx)).

Eligible vendors willing to participate may submit their expression of interest along with the tender fee for issue of bid document latest by 25th April'26.

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 3rd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India (Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)
The **Tata Power Company Limited** invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender package (Two-part Bidding).
(A) Supply and Supervisory services of 800 kVA, 33kV & 22kV Station Transformers for Backbay & Ambarnath Receiving Station. (**Package Ref: CC27NK001**).
(B) Supply of Nut-bolts for different Transmission projects in Mumbai. (**Package Ref: CC27TP005**).

Interested and eligible bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter before 1500 hrs. Wednesday, 22nd April 2026.
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website (**Tata Power → Business Associates → Tender Documents**) only.

NFRA’s statutory leap

Recasting India’s financial watchdog

P Saravanan
A Paul Williams

The 2026 Bill proposes a fundamental shift by transitioning the National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA) from a purely regulatory body to a formidable, independent institution with Body Corporate Status. This change grants the NFRA perpetual succession and its own official seal, providing the administrative autonomy necessary to hold property and enter into contracts independently of the Union government. Complementing this structural shift is the establishment of a dedicated NFRA Fund, which allows the authority to manage its own finances and reduces its reliance on direct budgetary allocations, thereby ensuring a consistent resource stream for complex and high-tech forensic investigations. Beyond structural changes, the amendment significantly expands the regulator’s disciplinary toolkit by introducing a ladder of intervention. While the NFRA previously focused on the heavy-handed power to debar auditors, it is now empowered to issue more nuanced responses, such as formal advisories, censures, warnings, or even mandate specific additional training for professionals. Furthermore, the NFRA’s remit is set to broaden to include oversight of the valuation profession. Under the new proposal, the authority will be responsible for granting and renewing certificates for valuer organisations, registering individual valuers, and recommending rigorous new valuation standards to the Union government, effectively becoming the primary gatekeeper for financial accuracy in India.

Strengthening the Audit Perimeter: The implications of these amendments are far-reaching, not only for the auditing profession but also for corporate India. One of the most notable changes is the elevation of the auditor’s independence. By introducing a mandatory three-year cooling-off period, the bill ensures that audit firms cannot immediately switch to offering non-audit services, such as tax, management, or advisory consultancy, to the company, its holding company, or subsidiaries. This measure directly addresses the long-standing issue of ‘economic interest’ conflicts, which have historically



ACCOUNTING. For accountability

undermined audit quality and compromised the objective reporting. In addition, the amendments strengthen management accountability by requiring Boards of Directors to provide formal, detailed explanations for every qualification or adverse remark made by auditors under Section 134. This prevents management from downplaying or concealing audit concerns in annual reports and fosters transparent communication between those charged with governance and statutory auditors. Finally, the Bill enhances regulatory alignment by empowering the National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA) to frame its own regulations and delegate functions to its members. This positions the NFRA alongside other statutory watchdogs, such as the SEBI and the Competition Commission of India, while simultaneously reducing the burden on the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. By enabling the NFRA to act as a specialised authority in financial reporting, the amendments ensure quicker and more technical responses to evolving corporate practices. Collectively, these reforms strengthen trust in financial disclosures, promote accountability, and align India’s corporate governance framework with the best global practices. While the Bill eases the burden on small companies by exempting a larger class of private entities from certain mandatory audits, it simultaneously tightens the oversight of public interest entities. The 2026 Amendment signals a move toward a high-technology oversight framework. For the NFRA, body corporate status and a dedicated fund provide the autonomy for a more aggressive regulatory posture.

Saravanan is a professor of finance and accounting at IIM Tiruchirappalli and Williams is the Head of India at Sernova Financial

Finance capital in time of war

With the Iran war, profits from defence production are set to increase. But finance capital is staying away and seeking higher yields elsewhere

MACROSCAN.



CP CHANDRASHEKHAR, JAYATI GHOSH

Capital, it is often argued, is the biggest beneficiary of war. However, in the Age of Finance, that assessment is coloured by the fact that it is finance capital and its institutions that are the profit-making leaders. Finance capital ensures this supremacy by subordinating the profit-making infrastructure to its ends. In a time of war, the principal component of that infrastructure is the military-industrial complex, which experiences a rapid run down of inventories and a lengthening order book and exploits that circumstance to inflate profit margins. US President Donald Trump has plans to massively hike defence spending with a \$1 trillion demand from the US Congress for the purpose. That should boost profits of defence equipment producing firms. In the Age of Finance, what finance capital seeks to do is ride on any profit machine to extract a share of the surplus for itself. Betting on the appreciation in the value of the shares of profit-making firms is the easiest route to extracting that share. And the surge in interest in the shares of defence firms accelerates the appreciation in the values of their shares, helping realise profit expectations. What has been surprising in the case of the US-Israeli unprovoked war against Iran is that the share prices of defence firms have not shown the expected buoyancy. Chart 1 traces the movement in the prices of an exchange traded fund tracking the share prices of US aerospace and defence firms from the beginning of February, through the date of start of the aggression (February 28), and till the date of launch of the now failed peace negotiations (April 10). What emerges is that this indicator of defence firm share price rose in the days preceding the start of the war and then began to decline and fell to levels well below the early February figure.

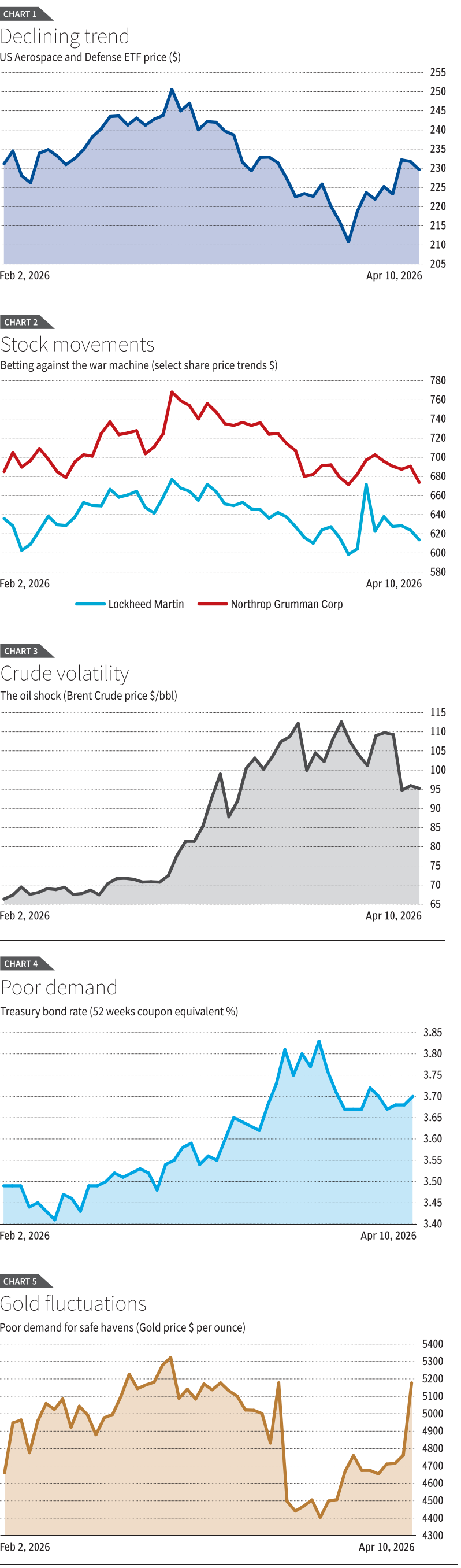
DEFENCE FACTOR Two of these firms were lead beneficiaries of a war in which the principal weaponry used was the means and instruments of deploying air power by the US: Lockheed Martin and Northrop Grumman Corp. They both experienced similar share price trends, with steep declines after the war began (Chart 2). A part of Trump’s supplementary budgetary demand for defence expenditure is to be spent on 85 Lockheed Martin jets, for example, as compared with an already high request for 47 jets in the previous year. Despite that, finance capital seems to be pulling out of, rather than seeking to profit from, the war machine. This action is clearly not driven by expectations of poor profit performance of firms that are the main beneficiaries of the US-Israeli war. Stakeholders in those firms are among the very few who would laugh their way to the bank as the world witnesses the political assassinations and civilian massacres that are central to the so-called ‘war’. Rather, given the footloose nature of finance, the explanation can only be that it has moved into areas in which the expected profits are even higher.

HORMUZ IMPACT That market is the one for oil and associated financial markets such as that for oil futures. With Iran shutting down the Strait of Hormuz and substantially reducing the access to energy of a range of oil importers, oil prices have soared. In the month following the beginning of the aggression, the benchmark Brent

Crude price rose sharply from around \$70 a barrel to more than \$100 a barrel and has fluctuated around that high level since. This bonanza from speculating in oil markets cannot however be the sole reason why the defence industry has not attracted a similar speculative inflow. There is no binding ceiling on the access to liquidity of financial investors. Therefore, there must be factors other than the higher returns offered by oil investments to explain the lacklustre performance of financial instruments linked to defence. One such factor could be that with Israel’s genocidal attack on Palestine, and the earlier US-Israeli attacks on Iran, speculation in defence stocks could have already run its course before the current war began, warranting a correction even when demand for defence equipment is rising further. The other explanation could be the uncertainty resulting from the unpredictability of Trump’s war mongering. Since profits from defence take time to materialise and may evaporate if Trump retreats, betting on military equipment producers may not be as attractive. Quick and easy profits from oil markets are clearly a better bet.

INFLATION FEARS But uncertainty does not seem to be influencing markets as much as could be expected. If that were the case, the consequence would be a rush into safe assets such as US Treasuries or gold. But as Chart 4 shows, yields on one-year Treasuries (or the inverse of prices) have risen, indicating that bond prices have fallen because of tepid demand. Here too oil prices have played a role. The spike in global oil prices (including in the United States) has revived fears of inflation. And bonds are bad investments in inflationary times. Moreover, the spike in defence spending would increase the federal fiscal deficit in the US, and the resulting rise in borrowing make bond holding less attractive. But, in addition, the signal bond markets are sending out is that there is no uncertainty factor dominating investor behaviour. It could be argued that Treasury assets are not being seen as such a safe haven — but the perception that there is no flight to safety due to uncertainty is also corroborated by the trends in the prices of the other typical safe haven asset: gold. As Chart 5 shows, gold prices did not show any sharp trend in either direction through much of the war-torn days and then recorded a collapse on March 20 only to slowly recover that level over the next 20 days. In sum, a reading of these indicators suggests that the war on Iran has not driven financial investors into expanding their holding in firms that are central to the military-industrial complex, even though they are the ones being rewarded by Trump’s militaristic adventurism and alliance with Israel. Rather, finance capital seems to be betting on something that Trump did not want — a spike in oil prices that would accelerate his domestic popularity decline. In this sense too, it is Iran that has won a war that it never wanted to engage in.

The defence sector’s lacklustre performance on the markets could be that after the Israel bombardment of Gaza and the US-Israeli attack on Iran last June, the run on defence stocks must have run its course warranting a correction



thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

April 14, 2006

Dept of Posts gets nod to invest in markets

In a significant move, the Government has allowed the Department of Posts (DoP) to invest up to Rs 10,000 crore from its life insurance schemes in various revenue-generating instruments, including stock markets. The move is aimed at enabling the postal department to reduce the budgetary deficit of around Rs 1,400 crore.

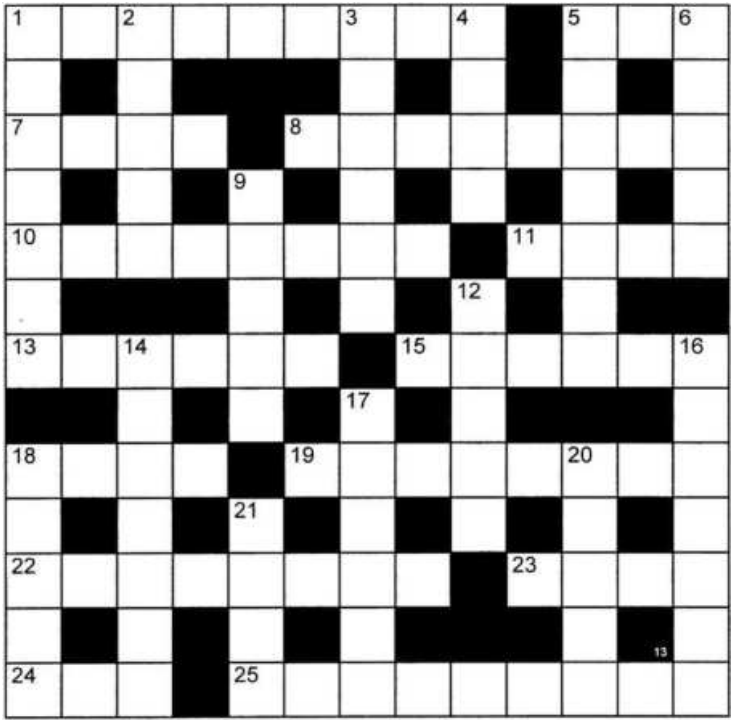
MUL to buy Suzuki’s stake in Maruti Suzuki Auto

Maruti Udyog Ltd (MUL) on Thursday said it would buy Suzuki Motor Corporation’s 30 per cent stake in the joint venture Maruti Suzuki Automobile India Ltd (MSAIL). MUL holds 70 per cent in the joint venture. The company will value the stake and merge by September 30, Mr Jagdish Khattar, Managing Director, MUL, said. The purchase of the unit will be effective April 1, 2006.

25 pc public holding for listing mandatory: SEBI

The mandatory requirement of minimum 25 per cent public shareholding for continuous listing of companies will come into effect from May 1. However, the new rules will not be applicable to government-owned and infrastructure companies, SEBI said in a circular issued on Thursday.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2657



EASY

ACROSS

- That may be inherited (9)
- Child’s bed (3)
- Hefty volume (4)
- Getting prepared for contest etc (8)
- A personal disadvantage (8)
- Pimple (4)
- It lowers the light (6)
- Jacket-like bodice (6)
- Walking-stick (4)
- Straight up (8)
- In parts, as serial (8)
- Strongbox (4)
- Cooking vessel (3)
- Absent-minded (9)

DOWN

- Hoicked up (7)
- Type of nose; upright type (5)
- Coarse canvas of jute or hemp (6)
- Wicked (4)
- Lame person (7)
- Too close-fitting (5)
- Underwater expert (5)
- Where river meets sea (5)
- Say in passing (7)
- Fuel rig (3,4)
- Higher in rank (6)
- Not expensive (5)
- Light banter, badinage (5)
- Palate of the mouth (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Lie about with a berth that can be come into (9)
- A small dwelling of old on which to lie (3)
- Book or Books returned to the writer (4)
- Getting ready for the carriages in Gateshead (8)
- It holds one back, the weight one has to carry (8)
- Post the third ahead of its exact location (4)
- Being less intelligent, it turns the lights down (6)
- Just the jacket for a dance (6)
- Give six of the best a sort of acne (4)
- Let vicar show it to be Perpendicular in style (8)
- In detachable incidents I spied company out (8)
- Peter is not in danger (4)
- A sylvan god to review with harshness (3)
- Likely not to remember how to make truffle go (9)

DOWN

- When given a tow, got married (7)
- Normal type is upright Italian capitalist (5)
- For sacking pal, rub it out (6)
- It is sinful to live it up (4)
- One maimed as clipper was broken up (7)
- On leaving tonight, will be intoxicated (5)
- One going down to work on translating Verdi (5)
- How to form the words to hum about (5)
- Make reference to mint one chewed up (7)
- Fuel source one will lubricate thoroughly (3,4)
- Higher up the scale one is confused as to the right (6)
- He appears in headwear that’s vulgar (5)
- Banter as separated from corn (5)
- Have nothing in for putting it up over one’s head (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2656

ACROSS 1. Jorum 4. Frantic 8. Configuration 10. Expel 11. Emus 12. Wile 16. Above 17. Peregrination 19. Retinue 20. Dance

DOWN 1. Jack the Ripper 2. Ran 3. Maiden 4. Frumps 5. Avalis 6. Twinkling 7. Convalescence 9. Plutocrat 13. Margin 14. Police 15. Reward 18. Inn

QUICKLY.
NSE gets MCA nod for coal exchange entity name



Mumbai: The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) has received approval from the Ministry of Corporate Affairs for the reservation of the name “National Coal Exchange of India Limited” for its proposed coal exchange venture. The approval is restricted to the company name and does not amount to any operational or regulatory clearance, NSE said in a press release on Monday. The move follows the exchange’s board approval in February to set up a wholly owned subsidiary for the initiative. NSE plans to infuse up to ₹100 crore as initial capital and hold a 60 per cent stake, with the balance 40 per cent to be offered to other shareholders. **OUR BUREAU**

Om Power Transmission IPO subscribed 3.33 times

New Delhi: The initial public offering of power infrastructure company Om Power Transmission received 3.33 times subscription on the closing day of bidding on Monday. The ₹150 crore initial public offering (IPO) received bids for 1,99,65,140 shares against 60,02,730 shares on offer, as per NSE data. The category for non-institutional investors fetched 7.06 times subscription. The quota for qualified institutional buyers received 3.65 times subscription and the portion meant for retail individual investors got subscribed 1.54 times. The IPO has a fresh issue aggregating up to 75.75 lakh shares and an offer for sale of up to 10 lakh shares. Price range for the IPO is fixed at ₹166-175 per share. **PTI**

BROKER’S CALL.

Haitong International

PAYTM (OUTPERFORM)

Target: ₹1,410
CMP: ₹1,107.25
We initiate coverage on One 97 Communication (Paytm) with ‘Outperform’ rating and TP of ₹1,410. We believe Paytm is well placed to drive the increasing adoption of retail digital payments in India owing to its market leadership position. Its sharp focus on digitizing SME merchants improved monetization capability thereby driving strong revenue growth. There are structural levers in play to drive improvement in Paytm’s payments margin owing to rise in mix of MDR linked payment instrument and product innovation. Its strong moat in merchant lending led by vast fleet on street should continue attract lending partners along with op. lev. benefits driving sharp uptick in core-EBITDA margin to 17% by FY28e. Across most operating metric Paytm outstand peers based on our analysis. We expect core-EBITDA/PAT to rise by about 4x each over FY26-28e and ROE should improve to around 12 per cent by FY28e. We use DCF methodology to value Paytm. **Key Risks:** Paytm operates as payment aggregator, lending service provider, stock broker and insurance distributor. Each of these segments are highly regulated and any adverse regulatory development can significantly impact its normal business operations; Paytm sources merchant/consumer loans on behalf of its lending partner. Any build up of systemic stress within the overall credit ecosystem could trigger underwriting cautiousness by lenders; and Rise in competitive intensity could impair its growth outlook as well as affect margin profile.

Motilal Oswal

ANAND RATHI WEALTH (NEUTRAL)

Target: ₹3,100
CMP: ₹3,590.60
Anand Rathi Wealth posted an operating revenue of ₹290 crore in Q4-FY26 (in line), up 30 per cent y-o-y but flat q-o-q, primarily driven by a 35/24 per cent y-o-y growth in revenue from the distribution of financial products/MF. For FY26, it grew 22 per cent y-o-y to ₹1,150 crore. Operating expenses for Q4-FY26 grew 55 per cent y-o-y to ₹200 crore, with employee costs/other expenses growing 67/15 per cent y-o-y. The management has guided for FY27 revenue/PAT/AUM of ₹1,420 crore/₹460 crore/₹1.2 lakh crore, with the long-term growth trajectory remaining intact at 20–25 per cent. MF yields remained stable at around 1.09 per cent. Management indicated that the recent regulatory changes around TER (effective 1st Apr’26) are expected to have minimal impact (-2-4 bp) and are unlikely to materially affect profitability. We have broadly maintained our earnings estimates for FY26, FY27, and FY28, as the company remains on track to meet its guidance. We expect AUM/Revenue/PAT to expand at a CAGR of 22/20/20 per cent, respectively, over FY26-28, with robust cash generation (₹8.3b of OCF during FY26–28E), an RoE of over 35 per cent, and a healthy balance sheet. We reiterate our Neutral rating, with a one-year TP of ₹3,100, based on 45x FY28E EPS.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

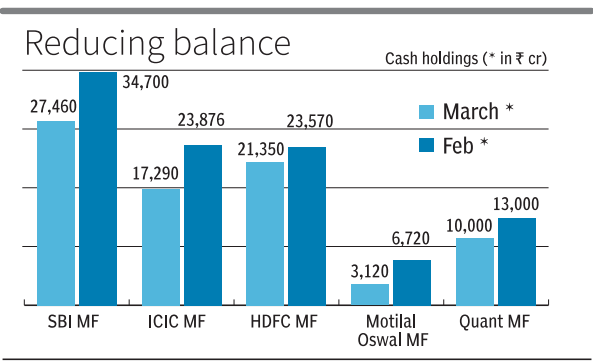
Amidst market fall, MFs lap up stocks, cut cash holdings to 16-month low

REPOSING FATIH. SIP inflows touch all-time high of ₹32,087 crore, equity investments hit ₹40,450 crore in March

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Mutual fund cash holdings fell to a 16-month low in March as fund houses used the market melt-down in March to accumulate more stocks amid rising geopolitical tensions. The bellwether indices Nifty and Sensex crashed 12 per cent registering their sharpest fall since Covid pandemic. The rising oil prices and sharp depreciation in rupee besides steady pull-out by foreign investors due to prolonged West Asia war hit investors’ sentiments. Despite the weak sentiments, MF investors continued to repose faith in equity investment. The SIP inflows touch all-time high of

₹32,087 crore and overall equity investments hit ₹40,450 crore in March. In this backdrop, nearly 60 per cent of MFs diluted their cash holdings to buy stocks during the market crash, while the rest either increased or maintained their cash position. Shweta Rajani, Head, Mutual funds, Anand Rathi Wealth, said MF cash holdings last month declined to a 16-month low of ₹1.86 lakh crore, against ₹2.09 lakh crore in February. Cash holdings fell by 12 per cent m-on-m basis and as a proportion of equity AUM, cash allocation stood at 4.72 per cent in March against 4.89 per cent in February, she said. MFs used the 12 per cent fall in equities in March as an



opportunity to deploy cash at lower levels. This apart, strong FPI outflows from equities made MFs infuse more in market to maintain stability in equity markets, she added. **INFLATION RISK** Going ahead, she said the expected fuel price hike may

create short-term volatility, particularly in inflation-sensitive sectors. However, the broader market sentiment is unlikely to be driven by one single factor. Even a sharp increase in oil and gas prices of 50 per cent over a 6 months will only have a modest impact

on aggregate corporate profits, said Rajani. Robin Arya, smallcase Manager and Founder of research analyst firm GoalFi, said low cash levels should not be mistaken for mutual funds running out of ammunition as they are getting steady inflows. Investment through SIP registered 61st consecutive month of positive flows and the pipeline of fresh capital ensures MFs are not dependent solely on existing cash reserves to support markets, he added. While geopolitical tensions and elevated crude prices remain near-term headwinds, the anticipated post-election fuel price revision of ₹10-15 per litre is largely priced in by markets, he said.

Downgrades unwind India’s premium, cap market upside

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The recent downgrades by global brokerages are expected to keep foreign investor flows under pressure and cap market upside over the next two to three quarters, driving a reset in India’s long-held overweight positioning amid earnings cuts and global reallocation. Over the past few weeks, Goldman Sachs, Nomura, Citi and Bernstein have downgraded India from overweight to neutral and lowered Nifty targets by 10-15 per cent, citing a weaker risk-reward relative to other Asian markets. Analysts say the shift reflects a deeper change in how

India’s growth and valuations are being viewed. “The target cuts reflect a fundamental reassessment, not a routine revision. Global brokerages had constructed a bull case for India premised on an earnings recovery that kept getting deferred,” said Ajay Garg, Director and CEO, SMC Global Securities. **FPI OUTFLOWS** Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments, said, “Target cuts reflect lowered earnings expectations and reduced valuations ... due to higher energy costs and supply disruptions.” The impact is already visible in flows. Foreign investors have continued to pull out funds even after the



ceasefire, with outflows of ₹48,905 crore so far in April, taking the total FPI selling in 2026 to ₹1,90,046 crore. In March alone, FPIs sold a record ₹1,22,182 crore, according to exchange data. “FPIs continue to sell India because of premium valuations and slowing domestic earnings, with the pressure increasing during the conflict given India’s dependence on energy imports,” Nair said, adding that fin-

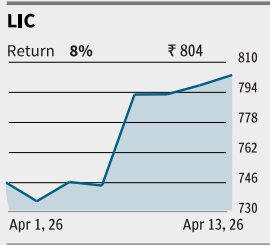
ance, technology and consumption sectors have been the most affected. Even so, analysts believe a significant portion of the selling may have already happened and brought valuations closer to more reasonable levels, creating selective opportunities. Sectors linked to domestic capex, defence and financials are seen as relatively better placed as investors turn more discerning. However, continued foreign outflows could lead to “bigger headaches on balance of payments,” and in a prolonged stress scenario could “cut 3-4 per cent off GDP growth,” Bernstein said. “The recovery time may take anywhere from a few

days to months...crude is likely to stay elevated this year,” which could push inflation above 6 per cent, delay rate cuts by at least two quarters and weigh on growth. “Taking these into account, we’ve cut the year-end Nifty target to 26,000,” Bernstein said. Nair said selling pressure could ease as India’s valuation premium over other emerging markets moderates and geopolitical risks recede. “India continues to hold a comparatively stronger earnings outlook for FY27 versus FY26,” he said, placing the market between value-buying opportunities and the risk of further calibrated downgrades.

LIC board approves 1:1 bonus issue

Our Bureau
Mumbai

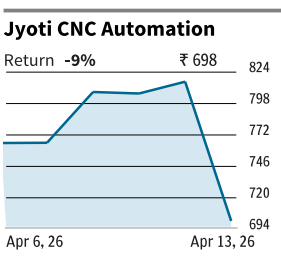
The Life Insurance Corporation of India on Monday approved a 1:1 bonus share issue, by capitalising its reserves and surplus. In a filing to the exchanges, the state-owned insurer said its board has cleared the issuance of one fully paid-up share of ₹10 each for every existing share held by investors as of the record date. The bonus issue will involve the creation of over 632 crore shares, amounting to approximately ₹6,325 crore, through the capitalisation of reserves and surplus available as of December 31, 2025. Following the issue, LIC’s paid-up share capital will double from about ₹6,325 crore to ₹12,650 crore, with the total number of shares increasing to over 1,264 crore. The company said the bonus shares will be issued out of its reserves, which stood at over



₹14.64 lakh crore at the end of December 2025. The issuance remains subject to shareholder approval. LIC added that the bonus shares are expected to be credited or dispatched within two months from the board approval, tentatively by June 12, 2026. The move is seen as a step to enhance retail participation and improve trading liquidity in the stock, which has been closely watched since the insurer’s market debut in May 2022. The shares listed at ₹875.45 on the NSE, a discount of nearly 8 per cent to the issue price.

Jyoti CNC slumps 15% after France probe into subsidiary

Our Bureau
Bengaluru



Shares of Jyoti CNC Automation tumbled 15 per cent on the NSE to ₹698.95, hitting a low of ₹691.90 on Monday, down from the previous close of ₹819.20, after the company disclosed an investigation involving its French subsidiary. In a disclosure to the stock exchanges, the company said that French authorities have initiated a probe into Huron Graffenstaden SAS and certain employees. The investigation relates to the alleged export of machines with dual-use technology in violation of European Union laws. According to the company’s filing, Huron Graffenstaden SAS has received notice of the actions and has refuted the allegations. It is currently seeking clarity from the relevant authorities and legal counsel, and in-

tends to contest the matter strongly. **INTERIM MEASURES** The disclosure further noted that, as part of interim measures, French authorities have temporarily restricted the director general of the subsidiary from discharging duties. In addition, certain bank accounts totalling about €4 million and two residential properties owned by Jyoti SAS have been seized. A formal judicial investigation has also been initiated against the subsidiary and some of its employees. Despite these de-

velopments, the company stated that business operations at Huron Graffenstaden SAS remain “as usual” for now, although some assets and services of employees involved in the investigation may not be available temporarily. Jyoti CNC clarified that it does not expect any adverse impact on its overall business operations. The company highlighted that, on a standalone basis, it contributes over 85 per cent of the Group’s revenue from operations, thereby limiting the potential financial fallout from the subsidiary-level issue. The company added that it is awaiting formal outcomes of the investigation while continuing to cooperate with authorities. However, brokerage Equis Securities believes the situation is likely to act as an overhang on the stock until there is greater clarity and resolution.

Citiust TransNet InvIT’s IPO to open on April 17

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Citiust TransNet Investment Trust on Monday announced the price band of ₹99 to ₹100 per unit for its ₹1,105 crore initial public offering (IPO). The issue will open on April 17 and close on April 21, the Trust said in a statement. Proceeds from the issue will be utilised for partial or full acquisition of securities of SRPL Roads Private Ltd and certain identified project special purpose vehicles (SPVs) — Thrissur Expressway Ltd, Jorabat Shillong Expressway Ltd, Dhola Infra Projects Private Ltd and Di-bang Infra Projects Private Ltd — and general purposes. Citiust TransNet Investment Trust (Trust) is a transport sector-focused infrastructure investment trust (InvIT), established to acquire, manage and invest in a portfolio of transport infra-

structure assets, including roads, in the country. **PORTFOLIO SIZE** The portfolio assets comprise a total of 3,406.71 lane-km (seven toll assets spanning more than 3,043.22 lane-km, and three annuity assets spanning more than 363.49 lane-km) across nine different States, according to the offer document. The sponsor of the Trust is Epic TransNet Infrastructure Private Ltd. The sponsor is fully owned by funds under Infrastructure Yield Trust — Infrastructure Yield Plus II, Infrastructure Yield Plus IIA, and India Infrastructure Yield Plus II. These funds are managed by EAAA India Alternatives Ltd (EAAA). Axis Capital, Ambit and ICICI Securities are the book-running lead managers of the Issue. The units are proposed to be listed on the BSE and the NSE.

ICICI Pru AMC Q4 profit rises 10% to ₹763 crore on higher inflows

Our Bureau
Mumbai



ICICI Prudential Asset Management Company has reported that its net profit in the March quarter was up 10 per cent at ₹763 crore against ₹692 crore logged in the same period last year, on the back of higher inflows. Revenue increased 20 per cent to ₹1,517 crore (₹1,269 crore). **MARK-TO-MARKET LOSS** However, it registered a loss of ₹89 crore in other income during the quarter, against ₹51 crore in the same period last year. The loss in other income was driven by a mark-to-market loss. Overall income jumped 8 per cent to ₹1,428 crore (₹1,320 crore). Nimesh Shah, Managing Director & CEO, ICICI Prudential AMC, said investors increased their equity exposure when mar-

kets fell last month, and this trend has continued despite volatility in markets over the last 18 months. Going ahead, the market may take a setback and industry flows may be impacted by geopolitical developments, but the fund house will strive to retain its market share and grow SIP flows, he added. **COST CONTROL** Overall expenses were down 3 per cent at ₹389 crore

(₹403 crore) due to lower employee benefits and other expenses. Fees and commission outgo increased to ₹111 crore (₹83 crore), while depreciation rose to ₹28 crore (₹23 crore). The fund house’s assets under management increased 25 per cent to ₹11.78 lakh crore (₹9.43 lakh crore). Equity assets were up to ₹6.20 lakh crore (₹4.88 lakh crore), while debt and passives increased to ₹1.99 lakh crore (₹1.72 lakh crore) and ₹1.84 lakh crore (₹1.24 lakh crore). **SIP INFLOWS** The second-largest fund house has equity and hybrid market share of 14 per cent and 27 per cent, respectively. SIP inflows in the March quarter increased 31 per cent to ₹5,104 crore (₹3,906 crore). The Specialised Investment Fund, launched in January, has an asset base of ₹1,896 crore.

Nifty, Sensex make smart recovery, but end in red

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Benchmarks ended Monday’s session in the red, though a sharp intra-day recovery from morning lows prevented a steeper fall. The Sensex closed 702 points lower at 76,847, while Nifty settled at 23,842, down 208 points or 0.86 per cent. The Nifty had opened 460 points lower at 23,589 before buyers stepped in, clawing back nearly 300 points to close near the day’s high. The trigger was the collapse of US-Iran talks and President Trump’s order to blockade the Strait of Hormuz, which sent Brent crude above \$100 per barrel mark. Markets are likely to remain volatile in the near term, with limited scope for relief until meaningful progress is seen in the West Asia conflict, said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd. While intermittent recoveries may emerge on value buying, the broader trend is likely to stay cautious, with near-term direction dependent on developments in the West Asia conflict, movement in energy prices and foreign fund flow trends, he added. The damage was broad-based as all sectoral indices closed in the red. Nifty Auto bore the brunt, falling over 2 per cent, with Eicher Motors and Maruti Suzuki among the biggest drags. Higher crude directly pressures auto margins through fuel and logistics costs, while a weaker rupee compounds the pain on imported components. FMCG, typically defensive, wasn’t spared either, as crude-linked input costs, palm oil prices, and slowing urban consumption squeezed the outlook for companies like HUL and

Downbeat			
	Close	% change	
BSE Sensex	76,847.57	-0.91	
Nifty	23,842.65	-0.86	
Nifty MidCap	57,513.30	-0.57	
Nifty SmallCap	16,762.00	-0.46	
India VIX	20.50	8.75	
Nifty Bank	55,605.05	-0.55	
Nifty Next50	67,123.30	-0.77	

Godrej Consumer. Oil & Gas and IT each fell over 1 per cent. Defence and select CPSE stocks were among the rare bright spots. HDFC Life, Adani Enterprises and ICICI Bank were the top Nifty gainers, signalling selective institutional accumulation even as sentiment stayed fragile. Midcap 100 fell 0.57 per cent and Smallcap 100 lost 0.46 per cent — both recovered sharply from intra-day lows, suggesting bargain hunting.

VIX SURGES India VIX surged nearly 9 per cent, breaking above the 20 mark — a signal that options markets are pricing in significantly more uncertainty. Aakash Shah of Choice Equity Broking said, “Markets witnessed a volatile session with a gap-down opening followed by a strong intra-day recovery, indicating buying interest at lower levels.” Foreign portfolio investors, according to provisional data, turned sellers on Monday by ₹1,983.18 crore. Vinay Paharia, CIO at PGIM India Mutual Fund, offered measured optimism: “The risk-reward is highly favourable for high growth and good quality business, wherein valuation as well as earnings growth both are in favour for long term investing,” noting that large-caps and small-caps are now trading near their longer-term valuation averages. Markets will be closed on Tuesday on account of Ambedkar Jayanti.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 207.95 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
ICICI Bank	1351.10	45.54	17.09	8.84	
NTPC	386.25	6.31	15.09	1.68	
HDFC Life	619.10	3.51	70.67	0.61	
Adani Enter	2129.00	2.40	17.38	0.51	
Avis Bank	1353.60	1.75	15.93	3.55	
Tata Motors PV	345.50	1.33	46.98	0.66	
ONGC	287.55	0.89	8.04	1.02	
Bharti Airtel	1870.90	0.60	30.77	5.25	
Coal India	435.10	0.50	9.01	0.90	
Dr Reddys Lab	1235.90	0.49	18.09	0.69	
Apollo Hosp	7516.50	0.11	57.92	0.71	
Bajaj Auto	9816.00	0.06	30.88	1.00	
Max Healthcare	951.70	-0.27	65.26	0.65	
Tata Steel	206.39	-0.40	28.25	1.56	
TataConsumerProduct	1090.30	-0.48	73.32	0.65	
Sun Pharma	1652.20	-0.62	36.19	1.60	
Tech Mahindra	1435.40	-0.66	30.63	0.93	
Bharat Elec	441.55	-0.70	54.13	1.45	
Asian Paints	2352.40	-0.82	57.71	0.97	
SBI Life	1914.40	-0.86	77.45	0.79	
Wipro	202.97	-1.19	15.97	0.53	
L&T	3964.30	-1.43	28.66	4.25	
Adani Ports	1494.30	-1.61	27.07	0.96	
Trent Ltd.	3875.40	-1.99	85.05	0.79	
JSW Steel	1204.20	-2.17	37.92	1.03	
UltraTech Cement	11502.00	-2.25	44.23	1.25	
Cipla	1211.10	-2.26	21.58	0.62	
PowerGrid Corp	300.35	-2.37	17.99	1.94	
Grasim Ind	2713.00	-2.46	19.49	0.95	
Bajaj Finserv	1788.30	-2.63	14.91	0.97	
State Bank	1063.55	-2.85	11.34	0.40	
NestleIndia	1226.10	-3.63	72.49	0.80	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	237.68	-3.95	94.09	0.71	
Kotak Bank	371.90	-4.26	19.68	2.51	
Hindico	978.25	-4.37	13.67	1.30	
HCL Tech	1409.40	-5.01	23.52	1.03	
Unilever India	2127.20	-5.44	49.71	1.73	
Titan	4439.30	-5.91	82.69	1.62	
IntiglobeAvi	4427.20	-6.27	53.31	0.98	
Eternal Ltd.	236.22	-6.30	986.84	1.56	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1004.10	-7.16	20.65	1.29	
M&M	3202.20	-7.72	23.08	2.63	
Eicher Motors	7050.00	-11.23	36.10	0.89	
TCS	2472.60	-11.52	18.09	2.31	
ITC	298.65	-11.78	18.07	2.63	
Infosys	1276.80	-12.01	18.49	4.10	
Bajaj Finance	998.95	-14.94	30.53	2.20	
Maruti Suzuki	13067.00	-18.12	27.53	1.57	
Reliance Ind	1315.10	-53.72	36.20	1.83	
HDFC Bank	794.70	-52.09	15.80	11.13	

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 517.95 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Adani Power	181.35	64.69	30.95	3.15	
Tata Power	409.55	48.20	26.13	2.88	
Vedanta	752.55	35.50	17.76	5.38	
Solar Industries	1452.50	31.08	86.09	1.49	
AvenueSuper	4448.00	19.70	101.06	2.75	
Adani Energy Solutions	1175.30	17.04	59.23	1.71	
Britannia Ind	5589.00	10.48	55.71	2.77	
Siemens Energy India	2849.20	8.91	85.89	1.06	
Torrent Pharma	4181.00	7.62	62.28	1.84	
Magadan Dock	2494.80	7.30	41.82	0.80	
ZyklusSciences	922.40	4.94	18.47	0.97	
AdaniGreenenergy	1085.45	0.09	96.33	1.53	
Jindal Steel	1218.50	-0.73	61.65	1.90	
Shree Cement	24300.00	-1.51	48.81	1.37	
Dif	568.40	-2.17	31.77	1.53	
Bank Of Baroda	275.72	-2.46	7.26	2.15	
Hindus Zinc	562.55	-2.51	20.14	1.03	
Gall India	153.71	-2.82	11.74	1.74	
MuthootFin	3562.30	-3.51	16.53	1.61	
Varun Beverages	430.60	-3.86	47.56	2.48	
Abb India	6828.50	-4.59	85.81	1.51	
Macrotech Developers	820.70	-4.65	24.51	0.97	
Power Finance	433.55	-5.55	4.29	2.65	
Tata Capital	321.65	-6.04	29.90	0.58	
HindustanAeronautics	4099.90	-6.59	30.82	3.27	
Ambuja Cements	441.00	-7.23	22.15	1.13	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	98.92	-7.61	18.45	0.84	
Ltimindtree	4466.60	-9.72	28.03	1.74	
Rural Elec	347.00	-9.87	5.30	1.82	
Punjab Natl Bank	110.73	-10.41	7.12	1.61	
Siemens	3343.50	-11.23	75.10	1.24	
Canara Bank	138.77	-13.13	6.84	1.97	
Indian Hotels Co.	634.95	-16.24	41.76	2.34	
Divis Lab	607.00	-16.68	65.00	3.24	
Bajaj Holdings	958.00	-17.05	12.24	1.79	
Bosch	36615.00	-17.51	39.17	3.14	
Indian OilCorp	141.08	-19.83	5.40	2.22	
AyudaMata India	1746.20	-20.21	24.54	1.05	
Goody Consumer	1059.90	-20.67	59.54	1.79	
United Bank	184.68	-23.78	7.44	1.50	
Pidilint	1326.50	-26.79	58.34	1.73	
Cp Power & Ind Sol	1176.10	-29.05	101.65	2.07	
United Spirits	1231.50	-30.60	52.08	1.53	
Samvardhana	1366.62	-36.62	51.55	2.90	
Samvardhanasolarint	119.11	-38.11	3.15	2.22	
Hdfc AMC	2546.10	-42.10	37.95	2.18	
Cummins India	4949.01	-56.17	61.72	2.84	
Tvs Motor Corp	3738.10	-67.49	58.16	3.69	
Tata Motors Cv	429.80	-87.02	96.11	3.78	
CholamandaminiFin	1597.20	-89.46	26.49	2.71	

Pls: Impact on index movement

● SOUTH FOCUS

Goyal targets DMK, alleges corruption and weak governance in Tamil Nadu

TIME FOR CHANGE. TN has immense strengths but is not achieving its true potential under the DMK, says Union Commerce Minister

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal on Monday launched a strong attack on Chief Minister MK Stalin and the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), alleging corruption, weak governance and a growing disconnect with public sentiment in Tamil Nadu.

ANTI-INCUMBENCY
There is massive anti-incumbency building against the DMK government; businesses are facing increased pressure due to multiple power centres within the government, he told journalists of *The Hindu* Group on Monday.

“Drug abuse is another major issue that, at different points, has been brought to

my attention. We will have to focus on this issue after May 4 once the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazagam (AIADMK) General Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami gets sworn in as the next Chief Minister,” said Goyal, who is also in charge of the BJP’s Tamil Nadu Assembly polls.

The AIADMK is leading the NDA in Tamil Nadu in this election. Goyal also accused the DMK of failing to unlock Tamil Nadu’s economic potential.

‘SEVERAL HURDLES’
The State has immense strengths, but under the DMK government, it is not achieving its true potential. Investors were being driven away due to bureaucratic hurdles and corruption, he said, noting that a large global fund exited its Chen-



RED FLAG. There is massive anti-incumbency building against the DMK, said Piyush Goyal BUOY GHOSH

nai project after failing to secure clearances. “If you make electricity rates so high, you are driving the industry from the State. If you don’t create an enabling environment of getting all clearances and getting land and facilitation quickly, you scare away in-

vestors from the State,” he said.

CENTRAL PROJECTS
The DMK government kept neglecting development and relied heavily on Central projects in areas such as highways, ports and airports, he noted. The DMK government’s confrontational approach with the Centre had only deprived people of benefits from Central schemes, he added.

Raising the issue of dynastic politics, Goyal challenged Stalin to clarify whether his son would not become the next CM.

On instances of dynasty politics within the BJP, he noted that merit comes first in the party, and even second-generation members of the party are made to earn their positions and are not handed big positions easily.

QUICKLY.

‘AIADMK and BJP will make TN retrogressive’

Villupuram: Tamil Nadu Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin said on Monday that the AIADMK-led NDA will make the State “retrogressive” if they are voted to power, and appealed to the people to be wise in choosing the DMK to sustain the pace of growth. He said the people should reject the AIADMK in the Assembly elections as it had “conspired” to halt the monthly entitlement scheme for women heads of families.

“Prove in this election that the AIADMK and its ally, the BJP, have no space in Tamil Nadu. Annihilate them in the polls, and wisely choose the DMK to sustain the pace of growth in the State,” said the DMK youth wing secretary while addressing a campaign meet in support of party candidates Lakshmanan (Villupuram) and Gowtham Dravidamani (Vanur). He said the DMK would launch the ₹8,000 coupon scheme for homemakers immediately after it forms the government. “During the previous election, we won four out of seven seats in this district. Ensure we secure all the seven Assembly constituencies this time,” Udhayanidhi urged. 711



SC seeks ECI, govt response on PIL for voters’ facial recognition

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Monday issued notice to the Election Commission of India (ECI), the Centre and States on a PIL seeking direction to implement finger and iris biometric identification system at polling stations in the elections to prevent electoral malpractices such as duplicate voting, impersonation, and ghost voting. A bench of Chief Justice of India, Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi, sought the response of the ECI and the government to the plea. It also noted that the exercise will require a change in rules and will also involve a significant financial burden to the exchequer. It said the prayers in the petition cannot be considered for the upcoming elections, but whether such a recourse deserves to be followed for the next parliamentary elections or State polls needs to be examined.

The petition has been filed by advocate and social activist Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay, invoking Article 32, and has raised concerns over the continued instances of bribery, undue influence, personation, duplicate voting and ghost voting despite existing safeguards. ANI



● MEET THE CANDIDATE

TN’s lone transgender candidate Roshini up against heavyweights

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Meet 28-year-old S Roshini, the only transgender contesting in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections. In a tightly contested battle in the suburb of Villivakkam, she is taking on seasoned rivals from the major parties as a nominee of the Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK).

Roshini is up against Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam’s Karthik Mohan, All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam’s SR Vijaykumar and Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam’s Aadhav Arjuna, in what is shaping up to be a multi-cornered contest in one of the keenly watched constituencies.



S Roshini is contesting on Naam Tamilar Katchi’s ticket in Villivakkam BUOY GHOSH

SOCIAL ACTIVIST
A social activist who has been running an NGO for the past three years focused on the upliftment of people in hilly regions, Roshini is attempting to shift the narrative away from identity politics.

“Don’t look at me as a person from the third community, but look at me as a sister and an ordinary candidate. I am here to serve the people of the constituency and continue my work,” she told *businessline* in Villivakkam.

Drawing ideological strength from NTK Founder Seeman, Roshini said the party remains committed to its vision of a Tamil State, and is aiming to challenge the dominance of the Dravidian majors. “We want the defeat of both the

Dravidian parties that have ruled for over five decades.”

On the ground, Roshini echoes voter concerns over poor infrastructure and women’s safety. While her grassroots outreach, especially among elderly women, has earned her appreciation for clarity on local issues, many voters remain sceptical about her electoral prospects given the strength of her opponents.

YOUTH BASE
Roshini also weighed in on the entry of actor Vijay, describing him as a newcomer who is unlikely to have a significant impact in the elections.

At the same time, she expressed confidence in the NTK’s youth base, asserting that the party’s supporters remain loyal, and that it expects to improve on its previous vote share of around 8 per cent in this election.

● CONSTITUENCY WATCH

DMK faces multi-cornered challenge in Villivakkam as TVK makes inroads

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai



FORGING AHEAD. Karthik Mohan, the DMK candidate from Villivakkam in Chennai, engaged in a door-to-door campaign for votes BUOY GHOSH

Villivakkam, one of the largest constituencies in Tamil Nadu, has long been a stronghold of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), which won the seat four times in the last five elections.

The party suffered a setback in 2011 during the sweeping victory of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) under J Jayalalithaa. Since then, the DMK has reclaimed the constituency with back-to-back victories.

This election, however, presents a tougher contest. Apart from its traditional rival, the AIADMK, the DMK faces a fresh challenge from the newly formed Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, led by actor-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay.

Key issues such as women’s safety, law and order, traffic congestion and sewage overflows have become major talking points among residents.

Adding intrigue to the race is a face-off between two former associates — Karthik Mohan of the DMK and Aadhav Arjuna of the TVK. Arjuna had earlier worked closely with Udhayanidhi Stalin as a political strategist before entering electoral politics.

The AIADMK, meanwhile, was initially banking on senior leader JCD Prabhakar, a two-time MLA. However, his defection to the TVK forced the party to field former Member of Parlia-

ment SR Vijayakumar, who is known for defeating Dayanidhi Maran in the 2014 Lok Sabha elections.

The contest has also gained attention due to the candidature of Naam Tamilar Katchi’s Roshini, a transgender candidate, the only one from the community contesting in Tamil Nadu this time.

VOTER CHURN
Despite its status as a DMK bastion, the constituency is witnessing signs of voter churn. The TVK appears to be drawing support, particularly among younger voters and women who admire Vijay’s public persona.

“I voted for the DMK last time, but I will vote for TVK this time,” says Lakshmi, a 33-year-old homemaker from Bharathi Nagar. Her family cited concerns over women’s safety, the prevalence of alcohol and drugs,

and civic issues such as sewage mixing with drinking water.

Residents also point to recurring flooding of the Otteri Nullah as a major concern affecting large parts of the constituency. Traffic congestion remains another key issue.

At the busy New Avadi Road-Madras Tiruvallur Road junction, an autorickshaw driver said that ongoing Metro Rail work has worsened traffic conditions over the past few years.

He added that while the DMK retains an advantage, the entry of the TVK and a strong AIADMK candidate could lead to vote polarisation. He also flagged the presence of the Naam Tamilar Katchi, whose candidate Roshini is expected to attract votes in slum areas.

In this densely populated industrial constituency, residents are also demanding improved bus connectivity

and better roads. Mohan, son of Anna Nagar MLA MK Mohan, expressed confidence in the DMK’s victory, framing the election as a battle to protect Tamil Nadu’s rights. He criticised the AIADMK’s alliance with the BJP, and emphasised the need to defeat it.

His nomination filing drew attention when he was accompanied by VS Sabaresan, son-in-law of Chief Minister MK Stalin.

Aadhav Arjuna, in a recent post on X, said voters are seeking progress and are ready to support a leader committed to the welfare of all sections of society.

AIADMK candidate Vijayakumar, meanwhile, criticised the incumbent for alleged inaccessibility, and promised enhanced civic services, including regular piped water supply, a new MLA’s office and a government school.

● CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Sattur braces for multi-cornered contest with TVK emerging as potential spoiler for DMK

R Balaji
Sattur

The battle for the Sattur Assembly constituency is turning out to be a tight, multi-cornered contest. Tamilzhaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) has emerged as a potential spoiler for the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), threatening to chip away at segments of its support base.

Veterans of the Dravidian parties, splinter groups and disgruntled elements are in the fray, with caste equations driving the campaign. All major parties are targeting the influential Mukkulathor (Thevar) community, making the contest suspense-filled.

The All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-Bharatiya Janata

Party combine has fielded Nainar Nagenthran, who earlier represented Tirunelveli. The DMK-led alliance’s candidate is A Kadarkarairaj, a local leader banking on minority votes and support from the SC and ST communities, which are widely believed to have consolidated against the AIADMK-BJP alliance.

But that edge may not hold. A local leader pointed out that “TVK, promoted by C Joseph Vijay, could wean away a part of the minority community votes purely on his star value.”

This concern is echoed across constituencies, with the TVK contesting in all 234 seats, raising fears within the DMK ranks that even a small shift in minority or youth votes could alter margins.

The spoiler effect is compounded by the presence of



CELEBRITY VALUE. C Joseph Vijay’s TVK could wean away a part of the minority community votes purely on the strength of his star value, pointed out a local leader (FILE PHOTO)

smaller caste-aligned outfits. KN Essaki Raja Thevar of the Pasumpon Makkal Desam Katchi is contesting in alliance with the All India Puratchi Thalaivar Makkal Mun-

netra Kazhagam, floated by Sasikala and backed by Ramadoss, Founder of the DMK campaign leans heavily on welfare delivery. At a roadside meeting, mani Ramadoss. Essaki Raja could prove to be “a fly in the ointment for Nainar Nagenthran”, says Saddam Hus-sain, a shopkeeper, as he watches the BJP candidate and GK Vasan, head of the Tamil Maanila Congress, canvassing in Sattur.

Nagenthran is meeting trade associations in the town known for its savouries, sweets and matchboxes, promising upgraded facilities for production.

Vasan stresses that cordial Centre-State relations can help develop the State, and promises IT infrastructure parks, minimum support prices for minor millets and support for the fireworks and matchbox industries.

DMK’S WELFAREISM
The DMK campaign leans heavily on welfare delivery. At a roadside meeting,

Veterans of the Dravidian parties, splinter groups and disgruntled elements are in the fray, with caste equations driving the campaign

Kadarkarairaj arrives in his campaign vehicle, loudspeakers blaring and drums beating.

He asks the women: “Have you received the DMK government’s ₹1,200 women welfare grant this month? Have you used the free public bus transport facility for women? Have your children had free breakfast at school? If you want these to continue, vote for the DMK alliance.”

“Remember the ₹8,000 coupon that the Chief Minister Stalin has promised for every woman to buy any household appliance of her choice once the DMK comes back to power,” he says. The crowd cheers and the convoy moves on.

Actor C Joseph Vijay’s TVK is banking on young and first-time voters, a segment that overlaps with sections of the DMK’s emerging support base.

Chottu Ajith, the TVK candidate, says: “The people, especially the youngsters, have had enough of both Dravidian parties.”

While acknowledging that he himself is a Thevar, he says the TVK is beyond such considerations.

“Youngsters, women and first-time voters are keen to support Vijay and TVK. They are also convincing the fam-

ily’s elders to change,” he insists.

Once a hub for the manufacture of pen nibs and still linked to fireworks and matchbox units in neighbouring Sivakasi, Sattur’s economy revolves around small industries and agriculture.

Industry leaders remain cautious, though. The head of a major industry body said they will not be drawn into politics, stressing the sector needs solutions to issues affecting matchbox and snack manufacturers, not just sops.

With TVK drawing youth and minority attention and smaller caste outfits fragmenting traditional vote blocs, Sattur is shaping into a constituency where the DMK’s arithmetic faces disruption — and even marginal vote shifts could prove decisive.

QUICKLY.

Gold subdued as dollar firms up, peace talks fail



Gold prices were subdued on Monday, pressured by a stronger dollar and the collapse of US-Iran talks, which fuelled inflation concerns and clouded the outlook for future interest rate cuts. Spot gold fell 0.4 per cent to \$4,728.59 per ounce as of 9.23 am ET (1323 GMT). US gold futures dropped 0.7 per cent to \$4,752.20. REUTERS

Palm oil rises as Iran war sparks buying interest

Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures rose on Monday, recovering slightly from the previous session's loss, as geopolitical jitters in the West Asia lifted crude oil prices and spurred buying interest in the oilseed. The benchmark palm oil contract for June delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange was up 19 ringgit at 4,557 ringgit (\$1,146.99) a tonne at the close. REUTERS

Aluminium rises to four-year high



London: Aluminium jumped to its strongest in four years after the US said it would impose a maritime blockade of Iran, reviving fears about weaker supply from top producers in the Gulf. Benchmark 3-month aluminium on the LME gained 2 per cent to \$3,570 a tonne in official open-outcry trading, its highest since March 31, 2022. REUTERS

Edible oil imports down 9.2% in March

KEY DRIVERS. Decline suggests a demand correction driven by high international prices, rupee depreciation

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Edible oil imports declined in March when compared to February due to lower demand.

Data compiled by the Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA) showed that the country imported 11.73 lakh tonnes (lt) of edible oils in March compared to 12.92 lt in February, a decline of 9.2 per cent.

BV Mehta, Executive Director, SEA, said the decline in March suggests a clear demand correction driven by high international prices, rupee depreciation and comfortable domestic availability, particularly from the mustard crop.

However, edible oil imports increased by 8.8 per cent during the first five months of the oil year 2025-26 (November-October). India imported 64.52 lt of edible oils during November-March of the oil year 2025-26

against 59.3 lt in the corresponding period of 2024-25.

The import data for November-March 2025-26 indicate continued structural dependence on global supplies.

FRONT LOADING

He said the sharp rise in imports between December and February pointed to front-loading by importers amid concerns over global supply disruptions, especially due to the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict affecting sunflower oil, supply-side uncertainties in South-east Asia for palm oil, and elevated freight costs linked to West Asia tensions.

Additionally, strong global demand, including diversion toward biofuels in major producing countries, has kept prices firm, prompting Indian refiners to adopt a 'wait-and-watch' approach.

"Going forward, imports are likely to remain subdued in the short term unless global prices soften or cur-



BIGGER PICTURE. Edible oil imports increased by 8.8% during the first five months of the oil year 2025-26 REUTERS

rency conditions improve, while in the longer term, India may continue balancing imports with increased focus on domestic oilseed production and diversification of sourcing to mitigate geopolitical risks," the SEA chief said.

While comparing the current price level with March

2025 prices, he said the prices of palm oil rose between \$50 and \$75 a tonne. Prices of soybean oil and sunflower oil jumped between \$190 and \$200 a tonne. The rupee depreciated by over 7.2 per cent in last year, a cause of concern to Indian importers and refiners.

Cotton body raises output estimate to 324 lakh bales

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The Cotton Association of India (CAI), the apex trade body for the fibre crop, has marginally revised upwards the crop estimate for the 2025-26 season, ending September, to 324 lakh bales of 170 kg each, from the earlier projection of 320.5 lakh bales.

During the 2024-25 crop year, the pressing estimate was 312.4 lakh bales.

This upward revision of 3.5 lakh bales follows the higher-than-expected production in Maharashtra, after offsetting the declines in Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh.



UNEXPECTED BOOST. This upward revision of 3.5 lakh bales follows the higher than expected production in Maharashtra

In Maharashtra, the crop estimate has been revised upwards by 7 lakh bales to 105 lakh bales, up from the earlier estimates of 98 lakh bales, said CAI President Vinay N Kotak and Chairman of the CAI Crop Committee Atul S Ganatra.

During 2024-25, production in Maharashtra was estimated at 91 lakh bales.

GUJARAT CROP DOWN

The CAI crop committee held a meeting on Friday to arrive at the new crop estimate for the 2025-26 season.

Around 21 members from all States attended the meeting and gave estimates for their respective States.

However, the crop estimate for Gujarat was reduced by 3 lakh bales to 72 lakh bales, from the earlier projection of 75 lakh bales. Gujarat produced 77 lakh bales during 2024-25.

Similarly, the crop estimate has been reduced by 0.5 lakh bales in Madhya Pradesh to 17.5 lakh bales. In 2024-25, production in Madhya Pradesh was 19 lakh bales.

In the North Zone, comprising Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan, the total output has been estimated at 29 lakh bales. In the Central Zone, production during 2025-26

was pegged at 194.50 lakh bales. In the South, output has been estimated at 95 lakh bales. Till the end of March, a total of 292.74 lakh bales arrived in the market.

Meanwhile, cotton prices have firmed up further, crossing the ₹60,000-mark per candy (356 kg) for the first time this season on strong demand.

Domestic prices are following global futures prices on the ICE, which inched up to over 73 cents per pound for July delivery on Friday, the highest since June 2024.

On Friday, the Cotton Corporation of India increased prices by ₹300 per candy. In the past two weeks, the CCI has raised prices by around ₹1,400 per candy.

\$1,400/tonne export floor price on honey to stay till December 31

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The Director General of Foreign Trade (DGFT), in a notification, said the validity of the existing MEP of \$1,400 per tonne on export of natural honey is being extended till December 31. Earlier, in January, the government had extended the MEP till March 31.

In August last, the government reduced the MEP from \$2,000 to \$1,400 per tonne, which was in effect till December 31, 2025, to enhance the competitiveness of Indian honey exports.

As per the latest export data available for financial year 2025-26, honey exports stood at 95,308 tonnes, valued at \$176.56 million for the April-January period. During financial year 2024-25, the country exported over 1 lakh tonnes of honey, worth \$206.47 million.



India is one of the major producer and exporters of natural honey and the main destinations are the US, the UAE, Saudi Arabia and Qatar.

SWEET REVOLUTION

India exports a variety of natural honey like rapeseed/mustard honey, eucalyptus honey, lychee honey and sunflower honey, among others. The major States producing honey are Uttar Pradesh, which accounts for 17 per

cent of the national output, followed by West Bengal (16 per cent), Punjab (14 per cent), Bihar (12 per cent) and Rajasthan (9 per cent).

The government is currently implementing the National Beekeeping and Honey Mission (NBHM) as part of the 'Sweet Revolution,' an ambitious initiative aimed at promoting apiculture to accelerate the production of quality honey and boost farmers' income through scientific and organized beekeeping.

Implemented through the National Bee Board, the scheme was announced under the banner of *Aatmanirbhar Bharat* with a total budget outlay of ₹500 crore for three years (FY21 to FY23).

It has since been extended for another three years (FY24 to FY26) with a remaining budget of ₹370 crore from the original allocation.

Iron ore snaps six-day slide on surging oil

Reuters
Singapore

Iron ore futures rebounded on Monday, snapping a six-session slide to a one-month low, as surging oil and higher feedstock demand supported the market.

The most-traded September iron ore contract on China's Dalian Commodity Exchange (DCE) rose 1.26 per cent to 763.5 yuan (\$111.75) a tonne. The benchmark May iron ore on the Singapore Exchange was 1.08 per cent higher at \$104.6 a tonne, as of 0710 GMT.

Iron ore inventory at major Chinese ports declined by 0.16 per cent week-on-week, as of April 10, data from consultancy Steel Home showed.

Continued portside destocking and rising hot metal output keep prices supported, according to consultancy Mysteel.

GOLDEN HUES



FADING HOPES. A farmer checks his wheat crop before harvest as part of preparations ahead of the 'Baisakhi' festival at a village on the outskirts of Amritsar. The wheat crop is likely to be 5-10 per cent lower than initial estimates of 120 million tonnes. The crop has been affected by unseasonal rain and hailstorm PH

HyFarm, Sri BioAesthetics in pact to boost health of potato ecosystem

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

HyFarm, the agribusiness unit of HyFun Foods, has entered into a strategic partnership with Sri BioAesthetics Pvt Ltd.

A statement said the memorandum of understanding signed between the companies will see HyFarm and Sri BioAesthetics jointly develop and evaluate a preventive, microbiome-driven soil immunity model tailored specifically for India's potato industry.

This collaboration will address some of the most critical challenges in seed potato production and processing-grade consistency, which includes soil-borne diseases, yield variability and high rejection rates in processing



lines, it said. S Soundararadjane, CEO of HyFarm, said: "This collaboration with Sri BioAesthetics allows us to address one of the most critical aspects in farming — soil health — in a far more scientific and preventive manner. By embedding microbiome intelligence into seed production and crop development, we are working towards greater uniformity, lower rejection rates and higher recovery efficiencies

at processing level." As a first step in this collaboration, HyFarm and Sri BioAesthetics will implement the latter's SoilFirst programme, the statement said.

DEMO PLOTS

The programme is a microbiome-based framework that includes soil diagnostics, pathogen mapping, pre-plant soil conditioning, seed tuber microbial treatment and root-zone biological strengthening.

In the initial phase, 25 to 50 acres of demonstration plots will be established across key potato growing regions in Gujarat and Punjab.

The programme will involve a comparative evaluation between conventional practices and SoilFirst treated plots.

Natural gas: Go long at ₹254, stop-loss at ₹247

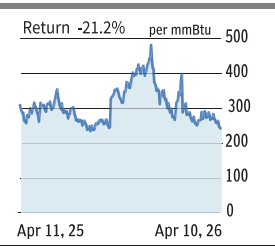
Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Natural gas futures are now trading at ₹254 (per mmBtu). The April contract has been in a downtrend over the past month, and has lost over 7 per cent so far this month.

COMMODITY CALL.

The contract recovered on the back of the support at ₹250. Although the broader inclination is bearish, there is a good chance for the futures to see an uptick. Such a potential move can lift the contract to ₹267, which is a trendline resistance.

A breakout of ₹267 could turn the outlook positive, where the futures can rally to



₹290. On the other hand, if the contract slips from the current level and closes below ₹250, it could lead to another leg of a decline, potentially dragging the futures to ₹235. Notable support below ₹235 is at ₹200. As it stands, even though the broader trend is bearish, there is a chance for April futures to rise to ₹267.

TRADE STRATEGY

Buy April futures at ₹254. Target and stop-loss can be ₹267 and ₹247, respectively.

Balco deploys AI humanoid agent for real-time training, operations and safety

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Bharat Aluminium Company Ltd (Balco), a unit of Vedanta Aluminium, has deployed Alaisa (aluminium artificial intelligence support agent), a humanoid, AI-powered assistant designed to enhance shop-floor capability, operational efficiency and industrial safety in aluminium manufacturing.

Currently operational at Balco's smelter complex in Chhattisgarh, Alaisa functions as an on-ground training, knowledge and decision-support interface for shop-floor teams.

The system integrates conversational AI with plant-specific operational intelligence to deliver contextual, real-time guidance on standard operating procedures,

Only forced sale of non-subsidised fertilizers banned in UP: Minister

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

As Uttar Pradesh has imposed a ban on forced sales of agricultural inputs like biostimulants and other products along with subsidised fertilizers, State Agriculture Minister Surya Pratap Shahi said the curb is only on tagging, and not on the sale of non-subsidised products.

Speaking to the media at Raisen in Madhya Pradesh on April 11, he said that since the tagging of other products while selling subsidised fertilizers was rampant, there was a need to stop the practice. But he clarified that there was no restriction if non-subsidised agricultural inputs are sold independently.

"The government needs to ensure that the retail shops selling urea, DAP, MOP and complex fertilizers either do not keep the other non-subsidised products or the subsidised products should be sold only through cooperative societies or government stores, if it is really serious about stopping tagging," said Bijender Singh, a retailer in Uttar Pradesh's Shamli district. He said that retailers could not say no to the company nor could they keep the stock with themselves if there are no buyers.

NETWORK DILEMMA

A top official of a leading fertilizer company said that there is already an established sales network, and they could not afford to build a separate one only to sell non-subsidised products. Since the consumers are the same, it is also cost effective when the products are sold through the existing network.

He also said that there is a "thin line" to differentiate between tagging and advisory, which the government



should not be worried much about, as the objective is larger — to help improve soil quality.

Union Agriculture Minister Shivrang Singh Chouhan has also been vocal against tagging of agriculture inputs, when farmers are buying urea or DAP, the two most essential fertilizers to raise productivity.

But many experts said that the move to ban is difficult to enforce on the ground as it might lead to further scarcity of fertilizers if retailers stop selling even the subsidised products.

"The main issue is low profit margin fixed for the retailers as a policy of the Centre. This seasonal business of selling fertilizers should have reasonable profit margin for retailers as well as befitting selling prices. While farmers in most places have become used to a higher rate to buy an urea bag than the government set MRP of ₹267, the rate has not been revised since the last many years," said agriculture scientist KK Singh.

Rajasthan, which became the first State in the country to issue an order curbing forced sales, has not been able to implement it. Farmers continue to complain about tagging, having no option but to agree to retailers' terms when there is an issue on timely availability.

QUICKLY.

Trump’s lawsuit against WSJ, Murdoch dismissed



Washington: A federal judge dismissed President Donald Trump’s \$10 billion defamation lawsuit against the *Wall Street Journal* and Rupert Murdoch on Monday over a story on his ties to Jeffrey Epstein. The ruling marks yet another blow in the Trump administration’s efforts to manage fallout over its release of the Epstein files. [▶](#)

Star Air to connect Mundra with six cities

Mumbai: Regional airline Star Air on Monday announced it will launch services to Mundra with 38 direct weekly flights, linking the port city to six key cities across Western and Northern India, starting April 25. With over 17,000 additional seats now available each month, the move will boost air connectivity and economic growth in the region, Star Air said. [▶](#)

Airlines may get ₹5,000 cr credit under proposed govt scheme

ARRESTING CRISIS. Likely to run for five years with ₹1,000 crore cap per airline with a possible extension

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

India is expected to cushion the impact of the West Asia crisis on its airline industry by allocating around ₹5,000 crore under a proposed new version of the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS), sources told *businessline*.

Accordingly, the airline portion of the proposed scheme is expected to run for five years, with up to ₹1,000 crore that can be allotted per airline.

“The allotment can be extended by a further ₹500 crore if the promoter also puts in ₹500 crore,” a source told *businessline*.

“The proposed new scheme is expected to cushion the industry from the pressures arising from the West Asia crisis,” the source added.

Notably, the allocation for airlines is part of a broader



NOT JUST FUEL. The government has already capped domestic ATF price increases at 25 per cent

proposal for a ₹2.5 lakh crore credit guarantee scheme being considered amid the impact of the ongoing West Asia war.

EXTENDED SUPPORT

As per sources, the Union Cabinet is expected to soon take a call on the scheme to support various sectors affected by the crisis.

Besides, the scheme is likely to provide up to 90 per cent credit guarantee coverage through the National

Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (NCGTC), a second source told *businessline*.

“The scheme is expected to extend support across sectors, especially to the airline industry,” the second source said, highlighting disruptions in routes, costs and operations.

Furthermore, sources said the earlier ECLGS had been effective in supporting businesses during stress periods such as Covid.

Recently, the Centre has taken various steps to shield airlines and protect passenger interests from the impact of crude oil price volatility.

PROTECTION BOOST

The Centre, via the Ministry of Civil Aviation, has implemented measures to cushion airlines against a sharp rise in operating costs driven by higher aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices, airspace restrictions, and currency pressures.

To arrest any substantial increase in expenses, the government has capped domestic ATF price increases at 25 per cent, resulting in a lower effective rise.

In another move, the government has removed airfare caps and kept the 60 per cent free seat allocation rule in abeyance to provide airlines with greater pricing flexibility.

Additionally, India’s aviation regulator has temporarily relaxed pilot flight duty

time limitations for long-haul flights in response to global aviation disruptions.

PASSENGERS GAIN

In addition, India’s airport economic regulator has ordered a 25 per cent reduction in landing and parking charges for domestic flights across major airports.

Meanwhile, the reduction in airport charges is currently limited to domestic operations. The decision will be reassessed before the end of the three-month period, based on prevailing conditions.

According to sources, in the absence of such interventions, airlines may have been compelled to undertake steeper fare increases, reduce capacity, and rationalise routes to maintain financial viability.

The government expects these steps to eventually stabilise and reduce airfares, thereby benefiting passengers, sources said.



GSK planning late-stage trials for its cancer drug

Bloomberg

GSK Plc is planning five simultaneous late-stage trials for a cancer drug it hopes will be a blockbuster, as new Chief Executive Officer Luke Miels tries to revitalise a company not known for its risk-taking.

Miels has been tasked with overhauling the British drug-maker, which has long struggled to allay investor fears about a lacklustre pipeline. After little change over previous CEO Emma Walmsley’s almost nine-year tenure, GSK’s share price has risen close to 50 per cent since Miels’ appointment was announced in September, outpacing large and medium-sized pharmaceutical companies in Europe.

AGILE STRATEGY

Miels earlier this year said that GSK needed to “have more scientific courage” and be more agile with opportunities.

But despite the investor optimism, there had been little tangible proof of a change in strategy — until now.

GSK plans to move its promising drug mocretatug

rezetecan, dubbed Mo-Rez, into three late-stage studies in ovarian cancer and two in endometrial cancer.

REWARD AND LOSS

The move, likely to cost tens of millions of dollars per trial, is more akin to rivals such as AstraZeneca which have stolen a march on GSK since it largely exited cancer drug development in 2015.

GSK returned to the cancer drug development space through the acquisition of Tesaro in 2019 and Sierra Oncology in 2022.

“We’re very much more agile now in how we view these decisions to accelerate the portfolio,” said GSK’s Chief Scientific Officer Tony Wood.

The first examples of GSK’s shift in approach are starting to come through, he said, adding the portfolio is “more competitive, better underpinned by the basics of science.”

Even so, five simultaneous late-stage trials are a risky bet.

On the other hand, a bolder approach could be just what investors want to see from GSK, according to Bloomberg Intelligence’s John Murphy.

Spacetech start-ups shift from R&D to scalable manufacturing

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

India’s spacetech start-ups are entering a new phase of growth, moving beyond experimentation to focus on scaled manufacturing, faster turnaround times, and execution reliability as global demand for satellite constellations surges.

Companies across propulsion, launch, and near-space infrastructure say the transition is being driven by the need to deliver consistently at scale rather than simply proving technological capab-

ility. “At Bellatrix, the transition from R&D to scaled manufacturing has been deliberate,” said Yashas Karanam, Co-founder and COO of Bellatrix Aerospace.

He added that the company has institutionalised the shift from flight-proven products to a “tightly governed manufacturing ecosystem” with rigorous qualification aligned to global standards.

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Similarly, Agnikul Cosmos is embedding manufacturing into the core of its design philosophy. “Our focus has



shifted from proving that the technology works to proving that it works repeatedly and on schedule,” said Srinath Ravichandran, Co-founder and CEO.

The company has built an integrated additive manufac-

turing ecosystem, enabling it to produce rocket engines “in a matter of days, not months”, while reducing supply chain dependencies.

Red Balloon Aerospace, which operates in the near-space segment, is also moving towards assembly-line style production. “The transition... has required a fundamental shift from iterative prototyping to process-driven, modular production systems,” said Co-founder and CEO C V S Kiran, noting that standardisation and in-house manufacturing capabilities have helped compress turnaround cycles. However,

scaling execution remains a key challenge. Karanam pointed to infrastructure constraints such as testing capacity and the need for stronger global proximity to win large contracts.

PROXIMITY HURDLES

Ravichandran highlighted the complexity of ensuring manufacturing consistency and systems integration, while also building teams capable of delivering at launch cadence.

Kiran flagged supply chain dependencies and regulatory coordination as ongoing hurdles. The surge in low

Earth orbit (LEO) satellite deployments is further reshaping business strategies. Bellatrix is taking a calibrated approach, building credibility with mid-sized operators before targeting large players.

Agnikul, meanwhile, is focusing on modular vehicle design, recoverability, and parallelised production to support sustained launch demand.

As the global space economy expands, start-ups say the next phase will hinge not just on innovation, but on their ability to deliver reliably at scale.

APAC emerges as growth engine amid data sovereignty push: IBM’s Hans Dekkers

bl.interview

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Hans Dekkers, General Manager, IBM Asia Pacific, outlines the region’s role as a growth engine, the rising focus on digital sovereignty, and the need for domain-specific small language models in enterprises.

Edited excerpts:

How does IBM view APAC? Are these among your fastest-growing markets globally, driven by untapped regional opportunity?

IBM is doing well in the Asia Pacific (APAC) for many reasons. First, the market is growing. Every country in our remit is growing fast, India included. APAC accounts for roughly 60 per cent of global GDP growth. Second,

it’s in tune with the recent technological developments. IBM is a big believer in open source, open platforms, and a large part of the competence in APAC is open-source driven.

The sheer response to global disruptions drives many discussions around sovereignty, localisation and AI. These discussions are up in the priorities of the APAC countries. We are seeing huge demand for sovereignty solutions in the region and are going to market with many new partnerships.

Airtel was one of them. It’s a multi-billion-dollar market opportunity for both companies. It brings enterprise-grade, specialised cloud capability to India.

For Indian companies and the government, if you want local, this is where you can deploy it; it’s a localised solution for all of our Indian enterprises. India is also growing fast since it has the right

demographics and is always hungry to learn. IBM has invested dramatically in India and will continue to. It hosts our software labs and development centres, which handle global missions.

What is driving the global push behind digital sovereignty and data residency?

Sovereignty, in essence, is autonomy. It’s about whether your data is yours, if the technical operating plane of your business is secured and autonomous, if the activity is auditable, and if you can comply with local legislation.

Sovereignty for us is over-encompassing. One of the driving forces is that many of our clients are realising, especially when it comes to AI, that they need to be in control of their data and models.

They don’t want to give away data to someone else or a broader platform. The enterprises have to make sure



We are seeing huge demand for sovereignty solutions in the region and are going to market with many new partnerships

HANS DEKKERS
General Manager,
IBM Asia Pacific



that their and their clients’ intellectual property is protected and governed. This is what we bring to the market.

Beyond sovereignty, what key cloud trends have emerged across APAC in recent years?

The recent trend, driven by sovereignty and cost, is a huge movement of on-prem again. One is a version of the traditional on-prem, where

clients are buying more compute for themselves. But also adjacent local service providers are buying compute for local companies. There is a movement of workloads that used to be on hyperscaler clouds, back on-prem due to sovereignty, AI cost, and controllability.

While the regulated industries are interested in this offer, so are the smaller enterprises — the up-and-coming

start-ups that need technology that can scale. This offering gives them an edge versus just jumping onto any infrastructure they can grab.

Given the conflict in West Asia, is there a concern that some companies may temporarily pull back on software spending to manage costs?

AI is embraced everywhere; it is changing how we look at our business processes and how we accelerate growth.

The companies that will outlast the rest are those implementing AI in the right and fastest way. They use it as an accelerator.

Companies that are not embracing AI yet are struggling. We’re helping them get to this new state of technology. It’s happening in different pockets, with some grasping the benefits already. Every sector will see a great impact of this technology.

While it will cause some disruption, it is natural and good for us all.

What are some of the biggest growth opportunities for IBM?

IBM is focused on three transformational technologies — hybrid cloud, AI and quantum. There is a huge opportunity in all three. With everything happening globally, there is a huge demand for these technologies.

IBM has a unique way of implementing technology. For example, we partner with many hyperscalers, but don’t have a hyperscaler cloud, which means we’re always on the client’s side. We can optimise the client based on the situation and where we feel it’s best. So, hybrid is the new landing spot. Sovereignty and cost will drive more to an on-prem position. AI will be a big opportunity, and we’re seeing the first benefits. In the world,

there will be room for 10 to 12 large language models (LLMs) trained on available data. They need huge data centres to compute and are relatively inaccurate. They’re not trained on enterprise data for the right reasons. IBM believes that the future is not just LLMs, but small, domain-specific, accurate AI models.

Every enterprise will have a multitude of small, domain-specific, highly accurate AI models, tied together through an agentic control plane. The agents can work with all of these small, domain-specific AI models. You can train them fast without massive data centres because they’re relatively small. The third benefit is that these models are local. They’re yours as an enterprise or as a government. You don’t want an AI model owned by someone else because it’s your data, model, and intellectual property.

Agilitas Sports signs partnership with cricketer Mandhana for One8

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



Abhishek Ganguly -
Co-founder & CEO of Agilitas

Agilitas Sports has inked a brand endorsement partnership with cricketer Smriti Mandhana for premium sportswear brand One8.

Under this partnership, Mandhana will play a key role in developing the brand’s women sportswear category.

The company also recently raised a fresh round of about ₹200 crore from existing investor, Nexus Venture Partners.

MINORITY STAKE

In December last year, cricketer Virat Kohli picked up a minority stake in Agilitas Sports for about ₹40 crore, joining the company as an investor and business partner.

As part of the deal, Agilitas Sports acquired Kohli’s sportswear brand, One8.

Abhishek Ganguly - Co-

founder and Chief Executive Officer of Agilitas told *businessline* that the partnership with Mandhana is a significant step in the brand’s journey to build a performance-first, globally competitive sportswear platform from India.

“Her role extends beyond being just the brand ambassador. She will play an integral role in developing the women’s sportswear category at One8. There is a gap in the women’s sportswear seg-

ment with the evolving needs of women consumers. So, she is working closely with us on building this category,” he added.

Ganguly said the company’s ambition is to build One8 as a global sportswear brand, which is expected to see a full scale consumer launch in the coming months.

Responding to a query fund raise, Ganguly said that the company has recently secured a fresh round of about ₹200 crore from existing investor, Nexus Venture Partners.

“We have witnessed strong growth in FY26. The manufacturing business under Mochiko has grown well. Last year, we launched the Italian sportswear brand Lotto in India and it will be one of the fastest consumer brands to reach the ₹100 crore annual run rate mark,” he stated.

Anthropic’s Mythos furthers AI disruption risk for IT sector

Rohan Das
Chennai

At a time when the IT services industry is learning to adapt to a new AI world order, a new announcement from Anthropic is set to raise concerns.

Reports around Mythos, the AI major’s latest frontier model, which it calls its most capable model to date and significantly better than the previous generation Opus, has set off alarm bells.

Speaking to *businessline*, analysts say that the model’s capabilities, especially in terms of security, can impact the demand for labour intensive testing and application support services that are priced on effort and volume.

Beyond just incremental growth in coding and software engineering capabilities, what is noteworthy about Mythos is its ability to independently find and work with software flaws at an ex-

pert level, they add. Though a fully functioning frontier model, Anthropic has not released Mythos as a usable product but rather put out a safety document which contains technical disclosures about its capabilities and risks based on internal testing.

MAJOR STAKEHOLDERS

At the same time, it has proposed to form a ‘controversial’ consortium of major stakeholders who will be granted access to the model to essentially find and fix software vulnerabilities.

The available information around Mythos shows that the model, within just a few days of testing, was able to find thousands of high-severity vulnerabilities in major operating systems, web browsers, and open-source software, some as old as three decades.

Such capabilities compresses the effort required to find bugs, security flaws, and logic errors and puts at risk



several domains within traditional IT services.

As Biswajeet Mahapatra, Principal Analyst, Forrester put it, prior generation models improved developer productivity and assisted with code suggestions while Mythos can autonomously discover, reason about, and connect previously unknown vulnerabilities in complex, real-world codebases.

GROWTH HEADWIND

A note from Kotak Institutional Equities says that the development further solidifies its previous estimate of a 3-3.5 per cent annual growth headwind for the IT services

industry for the next three years. “The Mythos model provides a firmer foundation for AI disruption-related concerns and could pressurise the valuation multiples of IT services companies,” it said. Further downside risks could also increase, especially if large capability improvements continue in future frontier models, it added.

“The most exposed areas are quality assurance, testing and application maintenance - segments built on repetitive, labour-intensive work. Models like Mythos do not eliminate demand, but they sharply reduce effort, which puts pressure on billing volumes and accelerates the shift toward outcome-based pricing,” said Iti Choudary, Senior Analyst, Everest Group.

Meanwhile, Anthropic had said that it will not be making Mythos public citing concerns of bad actors using the models capabilities to exploit software vulnerabilities

of various applications.

Such a restricted access could also be a major roadblock for service players. “Restricted access could be more disruptive than open availability. Early adopters will reset cost and delivery benchmarks, forcing the rest of the market to catch up. This creates a widening capability gap between top-tier players and the rest of the market,” Choudary said.

SOFTWARE PROJECTS

Despite its capabilities, analysts believe that Mythos can not run entire software projects on its own with work that involves business judgment, regulatory interpretation, and coordination across teams likely to remain relatively insulated.

Choudary believes that Mythos lacks proven reliability outside structured domains like coding and math, which means outcome-based, relationship-anchored contracts are far safer.

[illegible]

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Aero One WA (I)			1014.30	1009.30		ASML Tech			2866.65	2827.00		Central Mine P			165.75	170.15		HDF Financial			625.25	615.20		Jan Resour (C)			147.10	154.10		Lentask S (C)			547.10	549.10		The Electronics			122.75	124.30		Nimbus Pro			969.20	1003.80		Prince Items			239.85	240.15		SBC Exports (I)			33.25	33.11		SMB Fin			34.10	33.10		Stallion India			49.15	50.10		Tube Invt (I)			2745.60	2713.30	
3B Biochem			122.75	125.30		Ather Energy (I)			38.45	39.15		Chemil Samra (S)			24.98	23.30		Eterna (I)			26.87	25.20		Jack Engineers (I)			425.90	385.40		Jed Electronics			146.10	150.00		Nirbus Pro			78.20	74.07		Prism Cap (I)			4.32	4.54		SRM Concl			136.80	140.70		Unitech APL			35.90	36.30																			
A10 Ltd (I)			15.54	16.31		Atlanta Elec (I)			123.10	130.170		Choice Minc P			70.25	69.35		Exavia Life (I)			0.59	0.61		Herda India			116.25	123.30		Jaykay Ent (I)			125.95	135.85		Niveba			73.80	74.07		Prostan Info			146.10	148.85		SBI Card			67.75	67.135		Soda Tubes LI			164.95	149.65		Stellar H&H			46.25	47.00		Update Svc			15.90	14.90							
Aarti PhirLab (S)			68.90	69.75		Autonm Inv. (I)			44.10	42.95		Clean Air Inc			86.540	90.70		Exicom Tele			103.99	113.72		Hexaware Te			48.10	47.30		Jeena Shico (I)			665.90	659.90		LKP Fin			115.70	185.85		Nyomoo Fite			116.10	185.85		Protean Eng			53.20	53.70		Sedema Tech			164.80	165.70		SIN Network (I)			21.26	21.83		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Terra H&H			13.92	13.37	
Aayush Well (S)			69.29	74.66		Autopal Inv.			65.88	63.95		Cano Max Envi			86.91	88.45		Exoco Tiles (I)			7.34	6.61		Hi-Tech Tech (I)			86.37	84.97		Jinkushu Ind			54.77	65.69		NMOC Fint			42.02	41.49		Socoma Metals			146.80	165.70		SIN Network (I)			21.26	21.83		Terra H&H			13.92	13.37		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15													
ABC Gas			85.25	87.30		Avant Ind (I)			152.50	150.55		CMS Info Sys			28.60	30.45		Exoat Tech (I)			0.21	0.22		Highway Infra (I)			50.51	51.35		KNK India (I)			275.50	289.15		Nopgreen			93.33	104.21		PQV Infra (I)			4.02	4.10		Pudana Futur			303.70	301.65		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15													
Ace Software			170.20	169.65		Avalo Ind (I)			122.15	120.15		Avanti Ind (I)			152.50	150.55		Exoat Tech (I)			0.21	0.22		Highway Infra (I)			50.51	51.35		KNK India (I)			275.50	289.15		Nopgreen			93.33	104.21		PQV Infra (I)			4.02	4.10		Pudana Futur			303.70	301.65		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15													
Adani Infra (I)			182.30	179.75		Bajaj HsgFin			85.94	85.10		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
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Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85		Omeca Int (I)			75.86	75.86		Rajput S&B			125.05	126.10		Shanky Eng (I)			194.85	194.85		Sulja Tra			28.27	26.85		Vedant Fash (I)			39.45	42.15							
Aditya Birla (I)			101.10	102.93		Bajaj Steel (I)			474.35	464.60		Crestor Ind (I)			7.29	7.07		Fiscer Mgmt (I)			42.80	42.80		HMLA Aggro (I)			23.80	26.85		JTL Ind (I)			63.70	64.18		Magaell Cloud (I)			26.14	26.85																																					